

Problem of Evil — Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

MASTER LEARNING SEQUENCE | definition -> doctrine/argument -> objections/replies -> comparison -> exam conversion -> final register

• BASIC CONCEPTUAL ROUTE

Scope, syllabus mapping, evidence discipline and package coverage -> Source-complete coverage ledger and answer-worthiness labels -> Current scholarly anchor — [SUPPORTING, NOT DOCTRINAL AUTHORITY] -> Roadmap -> Session 1 - Conceptual Method: What Problem Is Being Asked? -> 1.1 The object of analysis -> 1.2 Four distinct challenges -> 1.3 Defence, theodicy, explanation and justification -> 1.4 Kinds of evil -> + 51 continuation nodes



• PYQ AND PRACTICE ROUTES

Practice protocol — [CORE ANSWER] -> Part II - Thinker, Argument and Objection MCQs -> Set A - Core concepts -> Set B - Evidence and hard cases -> Set C - Indian comparison -> Part III - Remedial MCQs -> Set D - Comparative evaluation and answer control -> Set E - Advanced core bridges -> Additional remedial diagnostics -> + 23 continuation nodes



• OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH

Advanced-dossier reconciliation — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED] -> Advanced Seminar Modules - From Competent to Examiner-Grade -> • Modal logic without notation overload -> • The moral premises behind the logical problem -> • Freedom: value, range and responsibility -> • Natural evil: autonomy of creation and excess -> • Evolutionary evil and deep time -> • Rowe, Draper and cumulative evidence -> • Skeptical theism: three boundaries -> + 17 continuation nodes



• FINAL REGISTER CONSOLIDATION

Final Consolidated Register Notes - Problem of Evil -> A. Argument forms at a glance -> B. Distinctions that earn marks -> C. Western response bank -> D. Indian comparison bank -> E. Hard-case checklist -> F. Seven PYQ routes -> G. 10/15/20-mark answer spines -> H. Final judgement ladder

Every Indic technical term is translated on first use inside each visual card.

BASIC

Definitions, thinkers, argument structures, objections, replies and comparisons.

BASIC NODE 1 | Scope, syllabus mapping, evidence discipline and package coverage — continued 1/2

title: Problem of Evil

topic_key: philosophy-paper-ii-philosophy-of-religion-03

Catalogue identity: Philosophy Optional · Philosophy Paper II — Philosophy of Religion · philosophy-paper-ii-philosophy-of-religion-03

Generation: g2, 21 August 2026 · Approval: pending explicit topic approval

Evidence discipline: exact doctrine and PYQ wording/year/marks are controlled by repository owners.

Model answers are pedagogic, never official UPSC keys.

| Component | Count |

| --- | ---: |



BASIC NODE 2 | Scope, syllabus mapping, evidence discipline and package coverage — continued 2/2

| Direct verified topic-owned PYQs | 7 |

| Core diagnostic MCQs | 32 |

| Remedial diagnostic MCQs | 8 |

| Total diagnostics | 40 |

| Original solved Mains models | 5 (1 × 10, 2 × 15, 2 × 20) |

| Approval | false |



BASIC NODE 3 | Source-complete coverage ledger and answer-worthiness labels — continued 1/3

[FACT] identifies retained repository doctrine or verified question data.
[INFERENCE] identifies learner-facing organisation or judgement.
The ledger records where each source is retained rather than claiming completeness without mapping it.
Source corpus Final location Retention decision
--- --- ---
Canonical owner Problem-of-Evil.md Basic, Practice, Advanced and Register Core distinctions, theodicies, Indian parity, sacred/profane route, hard cases and answer architecture retained through the fuller complete session and premium answers
Complete learning session, Sessions 1–10 Basic Learning Session Full pedagogic sequence retained, including every visual, comparison, critique and practical implication
Complete learning session, Advanced Modules 11–34 Optional Advanced Full advanced seminar retained after practice; no modal or meta-ethical detail is required for a core answer



BASIC NODE 4 | Source-complete coverage ledger and answer-worthiness labels — continued 2/3

Complete learning session, conceptual drills PYQs and Answer Practice All five distinction loops retained before long-form practice
Premium workbook, Part I PYQs and Answer Practice All seven verified PYQs from 2019–2025 retained with full examiner-grade solutions
Premium workbook, Parts II–III Basic MCQs / Remediation All 32 core and eight remedial diagnostics retained with explanations and strict A→B→C→D rotation
Premium workbook, Part IV PYQs and Answer Practice All five original solved models retained
Complete learning session, final register Consolidated Register Notes Complete A–H register retained last
Philosophy of Religion advanced dossier Optional Advanced Promotion status and safe-use limits reconciled: skeptical theism and horrendous evils remain core; second-order tensions remain optional
Visible learning labels.



BASIC NODE 5 | Source-complete coverage ledger and answer-worthiness labels — continued 3/3

Logical/evidential formulations, Plantinga, Augustine, Hick, process theodicy, karma (morally consequential action) and direct PYQ routes are CORE PAPER II.

Formal reconstruction, objection–reply control, Indian comparison and graded verdicts are CORE ANSWER.

Existential, pastoral and interdisciplinary links are SUPPORTING.

Dense modal, Bayesian, deep-time, anti-theodicy and second-order epistemic disputes are OPTIONAL ADVANCED.

What not to over-study.

Do not memorise possible-world symbolism, invented probability figures, every process-metaphysics term or case catalogues of suffering.

Master the burden of each argument, one strong response, its residual cost and a precise Indian comparison.



BASIC NODE 6 | Current scholarly anchor — [SUPPORTING, NOT DOCTRINAL AUTHORITY]

FACT Fact: A Winter 2025 *Philosophia Christi* symposium, publicly described on 13 March 2026, examined new directions in skeptical theism, CORNEA, the amount of evil and excessive-skepticism objections.

FACT Fact: Cambridge's *Religious Studies* published a 2025 article on experimental-philosophy research concerning Rowe-style evidential and Draper-style probabilistic arguments from evil.

CAUTION Inference for answers: These publications show that the live debate has shifted beyond the bare logical triad toward evidential weighting and the epistemic cost of skeptical replies.

They are a contemporary anchor, not proof of any position.



BASIC NODE 7 | Roadmap — continued 1/2

| Session | Subtopic | Examiner task |

| ---: | --- | --- |

| 1 | Conceptual method | Separate logical, evidential, existential and protest problems |

| 2 | Classical logical problem | Reconstruct the triad, bridge premises and Mackie's target |

| 3 | Plantinga | Explain possible worlds, significant freedom and transworld depravity accurately |

| 4 | Evidential evil | Rowe, the fawn, noseum inference, probability and skeptical theism |

| 5 | Classical theodicies | Augustine, Irenaeus-Hick, Leibniz, greater-good and natural-law approaches |

| 6 | Non-classical theisms | Process, finite and open models; identify the changed attribute |



BASIC NODE 8 | Roadmap — continued 2/2

| 7 | Existential protest | Job, Dostoevsky, Camus, horrendous evils and anti-theodicy |

| 8 | Indian frameworks | Karma (morally consequential action)-rebirth, Vedanta (school based on the philosophical culmination of sacred revelation), Nyaya (school of logic and realism), Mimamsa (inquiry into Vedic duty), Samkhya (dualist school based on enumerated principles), Buddhism and Jainism |

| 9 | Hard cases and synthesis | Animals, evolution, hiddenness, heaven, afterlife and moral costs |

| 10 | Exam conversion | Seven verified PYQs, drills, model answers and final register notes |

PYQ priority: Very high.

The audited Paper II corpus contains 7 primary-owned questions, one in every year from 2019 through 2025 and none in 2018.



BASIC NODE 9 | Session 1 - Conceptual Method: What Problem Is Being Asked?

Route marker retained from the learner-v2 source.



BASIC NODE 10 | 1.1 The object of analysis

[THESIS] The problem of evil is not one argument but a family of challenges generated by the relation among a divine profile, the facts of suffering and wrongdoing, and norms governing what a good agent would permit.

It becomes especially acute for classical creator-theism: an omnipotent, omniscient and perfectly good God creates and sustains a world containing apparently preventable evil.

[QUALIFICATION] Topic 01 owns detailed analysis of omnipotence, omniscience, goodness, eternity and God-world relations.

Here those attributes are imported only as premises under stress.

Topic 02 owns arguments for existence.

Evil can rebut or undercut a proof, but this session does not repeat the proofs.



BASIC NODE 11 | 1.2 Four distinct challenges

- Logical challenge: Is there a contradiction between God and the existence of any evil?
- Evidential challenge: Even if compatibility is possible, does the observed amount, intensity and distribution of suffering make God improbable?
- Existential-religious challenge: Can a person continue to trust, pray or find meaning when suffering is personally devastating?
- Pastoral or moral-protest challenge: Is it ethically acceptable to justify another person's suffering as part of a cosmic plan?

[VERDICT] A modal defence can answer the first while leaving the other three largely untouched.

This is the master distinction of the topic.



BASIC NODE 12 | 1.3 Defence, theodicy, explanation and justification — continued 1/2

| Term | Exact burden | Typical example | Common mistake |

| --- | --- | --- | --- |

| Defence | Supplies a logically possible reason sufficient to block contradiction | Plantinga's Free Will Defence | Demanding that it prove God's actual motive |

| Theodicy | Claims to identify God's actual or probable morally sufficient reason | Hick's soul-making; process theodicy | Praising mere possibility as a historical explanation |

| Explanation | Gives a causal or structural account of why evil occurs | Free choice; natural law; karma (morally consequential action) | Assuming a cause morally justifies permission |

| Justification | Shows permission was morally right or at least non-culpable | Greater-good or freedom claim | Treating compensation as automatic justification |



BASIC NODE 13 | 1.3 Defence, theodicy, explanation and justification — continued 2/2

| Anti-theodicy | Questions the morality or possibility of comprehensive justification | Dostoevskian protest; post-Holocaust caution | Confusing refusal to justify with denial of meaning or action |

[THESIS] Compatibility is weaker than probability; probability is weaker than full explanation; explanation is different from moral justification.

A high-scoring answer states which burden is being met.



BASIC NODE 14 | 1.4 Kinds of evil — continued 1/2

- Moral evil consists in culpable wrongdoing by responsible agents.
- Natural evil consists in pain, disease, disaster and predation not directly attributable to a human choice.
- Metaphysical evil names finitude, limitation or imperfection as such.

It does not follow that every limitation is morally evil.

- Suffering is an experiential harm; wrongdoing is a culpable act or disposition.

Either can occur without the other.

- First-order evils are direct pains, losses and wrongs.

Second-order goods such as courage, compassion and forgiveness arise in response to vulnerability.



BASIC NODE 15 | 1.4 Kinds of evil — continued 2/2

The availability of a second-order good does not by itself show that the first-order evil was necessary or proportionate.

[MEMORY] Four controls: C-P-J-T - Compatibility, Probability, Justification, Target.



BASIC NODE 16 | Session 2 - Classical Formulation and Mackie's Logical Problem

Route marker retained from the learner-v2 source.



BASIC NODE 17 | 2.1 Epicurean attribution caution, Hume and Mackie

[QUALIFICATION] The familiar questions - whether God is willing but unable, able but unwilling, or both able and willing while evil exists - are commonly labelled the Epicurean paradox.

The exact popular wording should not be presented as a verbatim quotation from Epicurus.

The dilemma is transmitted in later discussion, prominently through Lactantius, and Hume's **Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion** gives a celebrated modern formulation through Philo.

[THESIS] J.

L.

Mackie's 1955 essay "Evil and Omnipotence" turns the inherited dilemma into a logical charge against the simultaneous affirmation of omnipotence, complete goodness and evil.



BASIC NODE 18 | 2.2 Formal reconstruction — continued 1/2

[ARGUMENT]

- God is omnipotent.
- God is wholly good.
- Evil exists.
- A wholly good being eliminates evil as far as it can.
- An omnipotent being has no relevant limit on eliminating evil.
- Therefore, if such a God exists, evil should not exist.
- Evil exists; hence the set appears inconsistent.



BASIC NODE 19 | 2.2 Formal reconstruction — continued 2/2

[QUALIFICATION] Premises 4 and 5 are not mere definitions.

They require an account of logically possible action, morally sufficient reasons, freedom, stable laws and goods that may entail risk.

The logical debate therefore turns on whether those bridging premises are unrestricted.



BASIC NODE 20 | 2.3 What counts as a reply?

[THESIS] The theist need not show why every actual evil occurs in order to defeat a bare contradiction.

It is enough to show a possible proposition consistent with God and evil, such as: God has a morally sufficient reason to permit some evil because significantly free creaturely agency is a great good that cannot be causally guaranteed.

[OBJECTION] This can look evasive: possibility is cheap, while actual horrors remain.

[REPLY] That objection changes the target from logical inconsistency to plausibility, evidence or moral adequacy.

It is legitimate, but it must be named as a new stage.



BASIC NODE 21 | 2.4 Omnipotence paradox and attribute control

[THESIS] Omnipotence means power to do what is logically possible, not power to instantiate contradictions.

God cannot make a free act both causally determined by God and libertarianly undetermined in the same respect.

[OBJECTION] Restricting omnipotence to the logically possible may merely define away the problem.

[REPLY] Logical possibility is not an ad hoc restriction invented for evil; it is part of the standard concept of power.

Yet the critic can still ask why a logically possible, better feasible world was not actualized.

That moves toward Plantinga's world-feasibility claim and then toward evidential comparison.

[VERDICT] Mackie's argument remains pedagogically decisive because it forces the theist to state the hidden moral and modal assumptions.

Its original strict inconsistency charge is weaker once a coherent freedom-based possibility is admitted, but the evidential successor remains powerful.



BASIC NODE 22 | Session 3 - Plantinga's Free Will Defence

Route marker retained from the learner-v2 source.



BASIC NODE 23 | 3.1 Significant freedom and possible worlds — continued 1/2

[THESIS] Alvin Plantinga's Free Will Defence aims at the logical problem.

A person is significantly free with respect to an action when the action is morally significant and the person is free to perform or refrain from it.

A world containing such agency may be more valuable than a world of determined conformity.

[ARGUMENT]

- Significant freedom is a great good.
- If God causally determines every significantly free choice to be right, the choice is not libertarianly free in relation to God.
- It is possible that every world feasible for God that includes significantly free creatures also includes at least some wrongdoing.
- If so, God's inability to actualize freedom-with-guaranteed-goodness is not lack of omnipotence, because the proposed object is not a feasible world God can strongly actualize.



BASIC NODE 24 | 3.1 Significant freedom and possible worlds — continued 2/2

- Therefore God's existence is logically compatible with moral evil.



BASIC NODE 25 | 3.2 Transworld depravity accurately stated — continued 1/2

[QUALIFICATION] Transworld depravity is not the claim that every person is maximally wicked or always chooses evil.

It is a technical modal possibility: for any creaturely essence God might instantiate with significant freedom, in every feasible world where that essence is significantly free, it goes wrong in at least one relevant circumstance.

Plantinga needs the possibility of this condition, not proof that it actually obtains.

[OBJECTION] Why could God not create free persons who always freely choose the good, as the blessed might in heaven?

[REPLY] A world-description in which creatures happen always to choose rightly may be logically describable, yet not strongly actualizable by God if the counterfactuals of their free choices are not under divine control.



BASIC NODE 26 | 3.2 Transworld depravity accurately stated — continued 2/2

The heaven objection remains a plausibility pressure: if confirmed freedom without sin is coherent eschatologically, the theist must explain why earthly formation requires a different risk structure.



BASIC NODE 27 | 3.3 Natural evil extension and residual limits

[THESIS] The defence is strongest for moral evil.

Plantinga suggested that natural evil could possibly involve non-human free agents; this is enough for bare logical compatibility if coherent, but it is not an evidentially attractive explanation for disease, tectonics or evolution.

[OBJECTION] The actual scale of natural and animal suffering far exceeds what creaturely moral freedom explains.

[REPLY] The theist may combine freedom with stable-law, soul-making or finite-creation accounts.

Combining theories, however, increases explanatory commitments and must not become an unfalsifiable list.

[VERDICT] Plantinga is widely taken to have neutralized the strongest deductive version of the problem.

He does not establish that God probably exists, that transworld depravity is actual, or that observed natural evil is justified.



BASIC NODE 28 | Conceptual drill

Classify each claim:

- "There is no contradiction if freedom possibly requires risk." - Defence / compatibility.
- "God actually permits suffering to mature persons." - Theodicy / actual reason.
- "The quantity of suffering is unexpected on theism." - Evidential challenge.
- "No harmony can justify a tortured child." - Moral protest / anti-theodicy.



BASIC NODE 29 | Session 4 - Evidential Evil: Rowe, Probability and Skeptical Theism

Route marker retained from the learner-v2 source.



BASIC NODE 30 | 4.1 Rowe and apparently gratuitous suffering

[THESIS] William Rowe's evidential argument grants that God and evil may be logically compatible.

It argues that some intense suffering appears gratuitous: an omnipotent, omniscient being could prevent it without losing a greater good or permitting an equal or worse evil.

[ARGUMENT]

- There exist instances of intense suffering that an omnipotent, omniscient being could have prevented without losing a greater good or permitting an equal or worse evil.
- A perfectly good being would prevent any such suffering.
- Therefore, probably, no omnipotent, omniscient, perfectly good being exists.

Rowe's well-known example is a fawn badly burned in a forest fire, suffering for days before death, with no visible connection to moral agency or a beneficiary.

The case is illustrative, not a claim that one event alone deductively disproves God.



BASIC NODE 31 | 4.2 The noseenum inference

[THESIS] Evidential force depends on a noseenum move: "We see no justifying reason; therefore there probably is none." Such reasoning is strong when observers would likely detect the relevant reason if it existed, as when looking for an elephant in a small room.

It is weak when the reason could exceed their access.

[OBJECTION] God's providential reasons, long causal chains and goods involving many lives may exceed human perspective.

[REPLY] Mere logical possibility of an unknown reason cannot erase all evidence.

In ordinary reasoning, absence of expected evidence can be evidence of absence.

The real question is whether humans should expect access to divine justifying reasons.



BASIC NODE 32 | 4.3 Draper and conceptual Bayesian framing — continued 1/2

[QUALIFICATION] Paul Draper's evidential strategy, where used, compares hypotheses: the biological distribution of pain and pleasure may be less surprising on an indifferent naturalistic hypothesis than on perfect theism.

The point is comparative likelihood, not a numerical probability assignment.

[ARGUMENT] Conceptually:

Posterior plausibility of theism

depends on prior plausibility

multiplied by how expected the evidence is if theism is true.

If evolutionary suffering is much more expected on indifferent nature

than on perfect providence, it counts against theism,



BASIC NODE 33 | 4.3 Draper and conceptual Bayesian framing — continued 2/2

unless independent evidence or a strong auxiliary theodicy offsets it.

[QUALIFICATION] Bayesian language disciplines comparison but cannot manufacture agreed priors or likelihoods.

Avoid pseudo-precision in an UPSC answer.



BASIC NODE 34 | 4.4 Scale, distribution, intensity and hiddenness — continued 1/2

| Evidential dimension | Question |

| --- | --- |

| Scale | Why is there so much suffering rather than the minimum needed for freedom or growth? |

| Distribution | Why does suffering fall so unevenly, including on infants and animals? |

| Intensity | Why do some harms destroy agency rather than challenge it? |

| Duration | Why do harms continue when their lesson or causal role seems exhausted? |

| Hiddenness cross-link | Why does a loving God remain obscure to sincere sufferers? |

[QUALIFICATION] Divine hiddenness is a bounded cross-link, not a substitute topic.



BASIC NODE 35 | 4.4 Scale, distribution, intensity and hiddenness — continued 2/2

Here it matters because available comfort, guidance or unmistakable presence might reduce suffering without cancelling freedom.



BASIC NODE 36 | 4.5 Skeptical theism — continued 1/2

[THESIS] Skeptical theists challenge our entitlement to infer from "no reason we can see" to "probably no reason." Wykstra's CORNEA-style principle asks whether, if the proposed good existed, it is reasonable to expect that we would discern it.

Bergmann-style representativeness theses deny that our sample of goods, evils and entailment relations is representative of the full moral order.

[OBJECTION] Broad skepticism threatens ordinary moral reasoning: if unknown goods may justify any horror, how can one condemn or prevent evil?

[REPLY] The view can be restricted to global inferences about what an omniscient governor may permit, while preserving local duties based on known reasons.

We should prevent suffering because we lack authority to assume an unknown justifying plan.

[VERDICT] Skeptical theism weakens Rowe's inference but carries costs.



BASIC NODE 37 | 4.5 Skeptical theism — continued 2/2

It sits uneasily beside confident positive theodicies, can weaken providential interpretation, and must be bounded to avoid moral paralysis.



BASIC NODE 38 | Session 5 - Classical Theodicies and Defences

Route marker retained from the learner-v2 source.



BASIC NODE 39 | 5.1 Augustine: privation, fall and free will

Route marker retained from the learner-v2 source.



BASIC NODE 40 | Augustinian privation theory — continued 1/2

[THESIS] Created being is good insofar as it has being; evil is not a positive substance made by God but a privation, corruption or disorder of a due good.

[ARGUMENT] An eye is a good organ; blindness is the lack of a function due to it.

Likewise, a will is good as a created capacity but becomes evil by disordered attachment to a lesser good over the highest good.

Moral evil originates in defective creaturely willing.

In Augustine's larger narrative, natural disorder and suffering are connected with fall and punishment.

[QUALIFICATION] What it preserves or explains: It avoids a Manichaean dualism of two rival substances and locates culpability in creaturely agency.

[OBJECTION] A lack can be painfully real, so privation alone does not explain why God permits it.

Pre-human predation, disease and extinction strain a historical account that treats natural evil as punishment for a human fall.



BASIC NODE 41 | Augustinian privation theory — continued 2/2

The origin of a defect in an originally flawless creation is also difficult.

[REPLY] Privation is a metaphysical analysis, not denial of suffering.

Defenders may read fall non-literally as the structural misuse of finite freedom, but this revision weakens the exact punitive claim.

[VERDICT] The theory is strong against the claim that God created an evil substance and strong on moral disorder; it is incomplete as a morally persuasive explanation of innocent, animal and evolutionary suffering.



BASIC NODE 42 | 5.2 Irenaeus and Hick: developmental soul-making

Route marker retained from the learner-v2 source.



BASIC NODE 43 | Irenaean-Hick soul-making — continued 1/2

[THESIS] Humans are created as immature persons capable of development toward divine likeness; a world of epistemic distance, stable law and real danger permits freely achieved virtue.

[ARGUMENT] Ready-made innocence is not mature goodness.

Courage presupposes danger, compassion another's need, forgiveness wrongdoing, and responsible action predictable consequences.

Hick contrasts a soul-making world with a hedonistic paradise that continuously adjusts to desire.

Irenaeus supplies the image-to-likeness developmental theology;

John Keats supplies the phrase 'vale of soul-making';

Hick develops the modern theodicy.

[QUALIFICATION] What it preserves or explains: It addresses moral and natural evil within one developmental framework and explains why God is not overwhelmingly evident.



BASIC NODE 44 | Irenaean-Hick soul-making — continued 2/2

[OBJECTION] Much suffering destroys character, occurs before moral agency, or affects animals.

The quantity needed for growth seems lower than the quantity observed.

It also risks using victims as instruments for others' virtue.

[REPLY] Hick invokes eventual eschatological fulfilment so no life is finally wasted, and stresses that freedom and stable order require genuine risk.

[VERDICT] Soul-making explains a class of hardships better than horrendous or apparently pointless evils.

Eschatology may compensate or defeat evil, but compensation alone does not prove permission was justified.



BASIC NODE 45 | 5.3 Leibniz: best possible world

Route marker retained from the learner-v2 source.



BASIC NODE 46 | Leibnizian best-world reasoning — continued 1/2

[THESIS] A perfectly wise and good God creates the best among possible worlds, where 'best' concerns the complete compossible order rather than the local pleasantness of each event.

[ARGUMENT] Possible goods can conflict: stable laws, freedom, regular causation and rich varieties of being may jointly entail permitted defects.

God antecedently wills good and permits evil as part of an optimal totality rather than positively willing evil as evil.

[QUALIFICATION] What it preserves or explains: It highlights systemic trade-offs and rejects the naive inference that omnipotence can combine every isolated advantage.

[OBJECTION] The claim that this is the best feasible world is hard to verify, and global optimization can turn sufferers into expendable parts.

Voltairean ridicule targets facile optimism rather than the bare logic of compossibility.



BASIC NODE 47 | Leibnizian best-world reasoning — continued 2/2

[REPLY] The defender can distinguish 'best total world' from 'best event' and insist that victims are included within final divine goodness, not sacrificed outside it.

[VERDICT] Compossibility is a valuable modal insight, but the best-world claim requires an ethically credible goodness-to-persons account.



BASIC NODE 48 | 5.4 Greater-good, law-governed order and Swinburne-style responsibility — continued 1/2

[THESIS] A regular world is necessary for knowledge, prediction, action and moral responsibility.

Fire must burn, gravity must operate and biological processes must be sufficiently stable; otherwise consequences would be arbitrary and agency trivial.

[ARGUMENT] Stable laws create both enabling goods and exposure to harm.

If God constantly cancelled dangerous effects, agents could not learn causal structure, bear responsibility or help one another under genuine stakes.

Some writers, including Swinburne in standard discussions, emphasize the value of serious responsibility and the opportunity to respond to others.

[OBJECTION] Regularity explains why some harms occur, not why preventable excess, extreme intensity or selective miracles are absent.

A less dangerous law-system may still support agency.

[REPLY] Counterfactual comparison among entire law-systems is difficult, and complex life may require vulnerability.



BASIC NODE 49 | 5.4 Greater-good, law-governed order and Swinburne-style responsibility — continued 2/2

Yet the burden remains to explain why the actual distribution is not gratuitously severe.

[VERDICT] Natural-law reasoning is a plausible necessary-condition account, not a complete sufficient justification.



BASIC NODE 50 | 5.5 Punishment, discipline and providence - use with caution

[QUALIFICATION] Retributive punishment may explain a wrongdoer's suffering only where guilt, proportionality and legitimate authority are established.

It cannot be casually applied to infants, disasters, animals or inherited conditions.

Disciplinary suffering may sometimes reform, but uninvited observers lack warrant to label another's trauma a divine lesson.

[VERDICT] In an exam, present punishment and discipline as limited traditional motifs, then impose proportionality, innocence and victim-blaming constraints.



BASIC NODE 51 | Session 6 - Non-Classical Theisms and Revised Divine Attributes

Route marker retained from the learner-v2 source.



BASIC NODE 52 | 6.1 Process theodicy: Whitehead, Hartshorne, Griffin and Cobb — continued 1/3

[THESIS] Process thought does not preserve classical unilateral omnipotence.

Reality consists in becoming actualities with their own measure of self-determination;

God supplies persuasive possibilities but cannot simply coerce every event.

[ARGUMENT]

- Actual entities are partly self-creative; power is intrinsically distributed.
- God has a primordial aspect ordering possibilities and offering an initial aim, and a consequent aspect receiving the world's achieved values.
- Divine action is persuasive rather than coercive, not merely because God voluntarily self-limits but because unilateral control is metaphysically unavailable.
- Evil arises when finite actualities fail to realize better possibilities or when incompatible processes collide.



BASIC NODE 53 | 6.1 Process theodicy: Whitehead, Hartshorne, Griffin and Cobb — continued 2/3

- God is not the author of evil and receives the world's suffering in divine experience.

[QUALIFICATION] Whitehead is the metaphysical source;

Hartshorne argues against classical omnipotence;

David Ray Griffin develops process theodicy;

John Cobb systematizes process theology.

Do not collapse their distinct roles.

[OBJECTION] A God unable to prevent horror may not be worthy of worship and may not guarantee final victory.

[REPLY] Process thinkers answer that coercive omnipotence is incoherent in a world of genuinely actual others; supreme persuasive power and perfect solidarity are more religiously adequate than total control.



BASIC NODE 54 | 6.1 Process theodicy: Whitehead, Hartshorne, Griffin and Cobb — continued 3/3

[VERDICT] Process theodicy purchases divine innocence and solidarity at the price of classical sovereignty.

That trade-off is its strength and its cost.



BASIC NODE 55 | 6.2 Finite God, open theism and Molinism — continued 1/2

- Finite-God views preserve goodness while limiting power.

They relocate evil from culpable permission to cosmic struggle, but weaken assurance.

- Open theism holds that future free acts are genuinely open and known by God as possibilities rather than settled facts.

It reduces the control entailed by exhaustive definite foreknowledge, but critics call this a loss of perfection.

- Molinism, where invoked, appeals to divine middle knowledge of what free creatures would do in possible circumstances.

It seeks meticulous providence without causal determination.

Its controversial counterfactuals and the persistence of feasible-world limits must be acknowledged.

- Kenotic or cruciform approaches stress divine self-emptying, participation and co-suffering.



BASIC NODE 56 | 6.2 Finite God, open theism and Molinism — continued 2/2

They may transform the existential relation to suffering without by themselves explaining why permission was necessary.

[VERDICT] Revising an attribute can dissolve the original inconsistent set, but it does not make suffering disappear.

The problem is relocated to adequacy of worship, providence, hope and the metaphysics of divine-world interaction.



BASIC NODE 57 | Session 7 - Existential Evil, Protest and Horrendous Evils

Route marker retained from the learner-v2 source.



BASIC NODE 58 | 7.1 Job, Kierkegaard, Dostoevsky and Camus — continued 1/2

[THESIS] Existential approaches ask not only whether a proposition is coherent but what stance is humanly and morally possible before suffering.

- Job dramatizes lament, accusation, friendship's failed explanations and a transformed encounter.

It should not be reduced to a neat punishment theory.

- Kierkegaard, where relevant, illuminates the risk and inwardness of faith under objective uncertainty; he does not supply a standard causal theodicy.
- Dostoevsky's Ivan Karamazov refuses a final harmony purchased through innocent suffering.

The force is moral protest: even if an explanation exists, may one accept its price?

- Camus rejects metaphysical vindication and stresses revolt, solidarity and refusal to add human cruelty to an indifferent or absurd condition.

[VERDICT] These voices expose a gap between solving consistency and responding to victims.



BASIC NODE 59 | 7.1 Job, Kierkegaard, Dostoevsky and Camus — continued 2/2

They are not substitutes for formal argument; they test its existential and ethical adequacy.



BASIC NODE 60 | 7.2 Holocaust and post-Holocaust caution

[QUALIFICATION] Post-Holocaust reflection warns against speaking as if atrocity were a necessary ingredient in a divine plan.

Source-owned thinkers may differ: some revise divine power, some prioritize testimony and responsibility, and some reject comprehensive theodicy.

An UPSC answer should avoid attributing one uniform doctrine to "post-Holocaust theology."

[THESIS] The moral danger is instrumentalization: treating victims' suffering as a means to another person's virtue, historical progress or cosmic beauty.

[REPLY] A restrained defence may claim only that God and evil are not contradictory, while refusing to specify the purpose of each atrocity.

Religious practice may take the form of lament, remembrance, resistance and solidarity rather than explanation.



BASIC NODE 61 | 7.3 Marilyn McCord Adams and horrendous evils

[THESIS] Horrendous evils are participation in which gives a person prima facie reason to doubt whether their life can be a great good to them.

The problem is not merely aggregate quantity but goodness-to-the-person.

[ARGUMENT] Balancing-off adds enough independent good to outweigh an evil.

Defeat integrates or overcomes the evil within the sufferer's own life and relation to the good, so it no longer has the last word about the value of that life.

Adams's framework pressures theodicy to address personal redemption rather than cosmic bookkeeping.

[OBJECTION] Eschatological intimacy or redemption can sound like compensation after an unjust permission.

[REPLY] Defenders distinguish defeat from replacement: the evil must be personally integrated, not forgotten beneath unrelated rewards.

[VERDICT] The framework deepens soul-making, but it also shows why no general-purpose developmental story is sufficient for horrors.



BASIC NODE 62 | Session 8 - Indian and Non-Western Frameworks

Route marker retained from the learner-v2 source.



BASIC NODE 63 | 8.1 Method: no single "Indian solution"

[THESIS] Indian traditions do not share one answer because they disagree about creator, self, world, karma (morally consequential action) and liberation.

Creator-theist systems face a permission and administration problem; non-creator systems reframe evil as bondage, ignorance, craving or karmic causation.



BASIC NODE 64 | 8.2 Karma (morally consequential action) and rebirth — continued 1/2

[THESIS] Karma connects intentional action with morally structured consequence, often across rebirth.

It can explain distribution without making present innocence the whole history of agency.

[ARGUMENT] Action produces a causal potency or karmic consequence; continuity across lives widens the field in which consequences mature; present suffering may therefore be connected to prior agency; liberation ends bondage or the production of future consequences.

[QUALIFICATION] This abstract scheme differs by school:

- Nyaya (school of logic and realism): Ishvara (Lord or personal God) can administer unseen karmic potency and cosmic order;

God is not an arbitrary author but a just allocator.

The critic can still ask why an omnipotent administrator chose this painful mechanism.

- Mimamsa (inquiry into Vedic duty): ritual action and *apurva (unseen potency generated by ritual duty)* support karmic efficacy without a creator-God; the classical theistic defendant is absent.



BASIC NODE 65 | 8.2 Karma (morally consequential action) and rebirth — continued 2/2

- Advaita (non-dual school): suffering belongs to the empirical order structured by ignorance, karma and identification.

Ultimate non-duality changes the metaphysical status of the problem, but calling suffering empirically real prevents a crude "mere illusion" dismissal.

- Visistadvaita (qualified non-dualism): selves and world are real and dependent on a personal Brahman (ultimate reality); karma, grace and divine governance must be held together.

Do not assimilate it to Advaita.

- Dvaita: real difference, personal God and moral agency preserve a robust theistic framework; attribution should remain general unless a source securely establishes a specific theodicy.

- Samkhya (dualist school based on enumerated principles): without a creator, suffering arises through the conjunction and misidentification of purusha (pure conscious self) with prakriti (primordial material nature); discriminative knowledge yields isolation.

This diagnoses bondage rather than justifying divine permission.



BASIC NODE 66 | 8.3 Critiques of karma (morally consequential action) — continued 1/2

[OBJECTION]

- Victim blaming: present suffering may be treated as deserved.
- Regress: if every suffering is explained by prior deed, what explains the beginning of the cycle?
- Memory and identity: why is punishment just if the sufferer cannot remember the deed or if personal identity is disputed?
- Social legitimation: karmic rhetoric can naturalize hierarchy and reduce reform.
- Proportionality and mechanism: the link between a specific deed and suffering may be opaque.

[REPLY] Traditions can call samsara (cycle of rebirth) beginningless rather than posit a first deed; moral continuity need not require episodic memory; and present compassion remains obligatory because another's karma never licenses one's cruelty or indifference.

[VERDICT] Karma is structurally strong on distribution but morally dangerous when converted into retrospective certainty about a victim.



BASIC NODE 67 | 8.3 Critiques of karma (morally consequential action) — continued 2/2

Explanation must be separated from blame.



BASIC NODE 68 | 8.4 Buddhism: dukkha (suffering or unsatisfactoriness) and dependent origination — continued 1/2

[THESIS] Buddhism does not defend an omnipotent creator.

It begins from *dukkha*, traces its conditioned arising through craving and ignorance, affirms cessation and prescribes a path.

[ARGUMENT] The philosophical focus shifts from "Why would God permit this?" to "What conditions generate suffering and how can they cease?" Dependent origination avoids both an uncaused creator and a permanent self-substance, though it must explain karmic responsibility through causal continuity.

[OBJECTION] A diagnostic path may not answer why the world contains horrific suffering or why causal continuity is morally just without a stable self.

[REPLY] Buddhism need not justify a created totality; it offers a practical causal explanation and liberation project.

Responsibility can attach to causal continuity without numerical identity, though this remains contested.



BASIC NODE 69 | 8.4 Buddhism: dukkha (suffering or unsatisfactoriness) and dependent origination — continued 2/2

[VERDICT] Buddhism dissolves the classical problem by removing its divine defendant but retains the existential and ethical urgency of suffering.



BASIC NODE 70 | 8.5 Jainism

[THESIS] Jainism treats karma (morally consequential action) as subtle material bondage adhering to jiva (individual living self) through passion and action.

Influx, bondage, stoppage and shedding explain suffering and liberation through self-effort, discipline and non-violence without a creator.

[OBJECTION] Materialized karma and beginningless bondage raise explanatory questions; strict ascetic responsibility can become harsh if applied without compassion.

[REPLY] The framework links metaphysics to ethical purification and radical *ahimsa (non-violence)*, making prevention of harm central rather than passive acceptance.

[VERDICT] Jainism replaces theodicy with a bondage-liberation mechanics; it avoids creator culpability while retaining burdens concerning karmic proportionality and identity.



BASIC NODE 71 | 8.6 Bhakti and providence

[QUALIFICATION] Bhakti traditions vary.

Relevant responses include trust, surrender, lament, grace, divine companionship and service.

They should not be presented as a single proof that every suffering is providentially designed.

[VERDICT] Bhakti contributes an existential relation and practice; philosophical adequacy still requires an account of power, permission, karma (morally consequential action) and innocent suffering.



BASIC NODE 72 | Session 9 - Hard Cases and Meta-Level Critiques

Route marker retained from the learner-v2 source.



BASIC NODE 73 | 9.1 Animal suffering and evolutionary evil

[THESIS] Animal suffering is a central evidential challenge because predation, disease, parasitism and extinction precede human agency and often seem unrelated to moral growth.

[OBJECTION] Free-will and punishment theories are anthropocentric.

Stable-law and evolutionary accounts explain mechanisms and goods such as complex life, but not obviously the intensity and duration of sentient pain.

[REPLY] Theists may appeal to the value of an autonomous, fecund creation, regular processes and possible non-human redemption.

Each proposal carries speculative commitments and must not treat animals merely as instruments for human virtues.

[VERDICT] Animal evil sharply limits any total theodicy based only on human freedom or character.



BASIC NODE 74 | 9.2 Free will and heaven

[OBJECTION] If persons in heaven are free yet do not sin, why could God not create that condition immediately?

[REPLY] The soul-making answer distinguishes created innocence from formed character: confirmed goodness may be the outcome of a history of free development.

The critic asks whether horrendous risks are necessary for that history and whether all persons receive a fair developmental environment.

[VERDICT] Heaven pressures but does not automatically refute freedom-based accounts; it forces a temporal and developmental explanation.



BASIC NODE 75 | 9.3 Natural laws and preventable excess

[THESIS] A law-governed order explains regular vulnerability.

It does not entail that every actual harm or every degree of harm is required.

[OBJECTION] Selective prevention could preserve laws while avoiding isolated horrors.

[REPLY] Frequent hidden intervention might destabilize agency, but rare intervention need not.

The persistence of apparently preventable excess remains an evidential residue.



BASIC NODE 76 | 9.4 Afterlife compensation versus justification

[THESIS] Compensation gives a later good; justification shows permission was morally acceptable; defeat integrates the evil within the sufferer's good.

These are not equivalent.

[OBJECTION] Infinite future bliss may outweigh finite pain but cannot retroactively make using a person permissible.

[REPLY] A goodness-to-persons theory requires more than arithmetic: consent, relationship, redemption and defeat matter.



BASIC NODE 77 | 9.5 Epistemic humility versus skepticism

[THESIS] Humility recognizes limited perspective.

Skepticism becomes costly when it blocks all moral assessment, providential inference or positive religious knowledge.

[VERDICT] The strongest bounded position is asymmetric: do not infer confidently that every evil is gratuitous, but do not infer confidently that every evil serves a hidden good.

Act against suffering using known reasons.



BASIC NODE 78 | 9.6 Theodicy as explanation or moral legitimation

[OBJECTION] Theodicy can legitimate the status quo by redescribing oppression as discipline, karma (morally consequential action) or providence.

[REPLY] A morally responsible theodicy must be action-guiding: because agents do not know hidden purposes, they must prevent harms, resist injustice and refuse victim blame.

Any view that weakens compassion fails its own claim to goodness.



BASIC NODE 79 | 9.7 Does rejecting classical theism dissolve the problem?

[THESIS] Removing omnipotence, creatorhood or personal goodness dissolves the original inconsistent triad.

[QUALIFICATION] It relocates rather than abolishes questions: Is a finite God worship-worthy?

Can process God save?

Does non-theistic karma (morally consequential action) fairly distribute consequence?

Does Advaitic world-status respect empirical suffering?

Can Buddhism ground continuity and compassion without self?

[VERDICT] The 2024 PYQ is correct that the problem is concept-dependent, but suffering remains philosophically and religiously significant in every framework.



BASIC NODE 80 | Session 10 - Comparative Synthesis and Practical Implications

Route marker retained from the learner-v2 source.



BASIC NODE 81 | 10.1 Multi-axis comparison — continued 1/2

| View | Divine attributes | Cause/account | Natural/animal evil | Distribution | Ethical cost |

| --- | --- | --- | --- | --- | --- |

| Plantinga | Preserves classical profile | Misuse of significant freedom | Needs supplement | Weak | Can look modally remote |

| Augustine | Preserves profile | Privation, fall, punishment | Historically strained | Punitive | Innocent suffering and inherited guilt |

| Hick | Preserves goodness and broad power | Development under epistemic distance | Law-order and growth | Uneven opportunity | Instrumentalization; excess |

| Leibniz | Preserves perfection | Best compossible totality | Part of system | Global, not personal | Sacrificial optimization |

| Process | Revises omnipotence | Distributed power and finite becoming | Built into process risk | No unilateral controller | Weakened assurance |



BASIC NODE 82 | 10.1 Multi-axis comparison — continued 2/2

| Skeptical theism | Preserves attributes without reason claim | Epistemic undercutting | Unexplained | Unexplained | Moral skepticism risk |

| Karma (morally consequential action)-theistic | Just administrator | Prior agency and divine allocation | Across life-series | Strong explanatory ambition | Victim blame; opacity |

| Karma-non-theistic | No creator defendant | Moral causation | Across life-series | Strong ambition | Regress/identity |

| Buddhism | No creator | Craving, ignorance, dependent arising | Conditioned dukkha (suffering or unsatisfactoriness) | Not distributive theodicy | May seem diagnosis without cosmic why |

| Jainism | No creator | Karmic matter and passion | Bondage across jivas (individual living selves) | Karmic continuity | Ascetic severity |



BASIC NODE 83 | 10.2 Objection-response decision tree

- Identify whether the examiner asks contradiction, probability, responsibility, conceptual dependence or religious function.
- State the divine profile under examination.
- Reconstruct one argument formally.
- Deploy only responses that meet that argument's burden.
- Add one Indian comparison that changes the frame rather than decorating the answer.
- State the moral and religious cost of the response.



BASIC NODE 84 | 10.3 Practical religious implications — continued 1/2

[THESIS] The practical test of a religious response is whether it deepens truthfulness, compassion and responsibility rather than silencing lament.

- Prayer: may include petition, lament, protest and solidarity; unanswered prayer intensifies rather than cancels the philosophical issue.
- Trust: can be retained as fallible commitment without claiming knowledge of each divine reason.
- Protest: need not be unbelief;

Job-like protest can occur within a relationship.

- Compassion: precedes explanation in pastoral settings.
- Moral action: no theodicy licenses passivity.

Agents must prevent avoidable suffering because they are not entitled to assume it is necessary.



BASIC NODE 85 | 10.3 Practical religious implications — continued 2/2

- Religious commitment: may survive through a cumulative judgement involving experience, practice and other arguments, but evil remains a defeater that must be answered rather than ignored.

[VERDICT] The mature position combines conceptual rigor, epistemic humility and victim-centered action.

PRACTICE

Visual route maps only: diagnostic coverage, PYQ demands and answer pathways.

PRACTICE NODE 1 | Set B - Evidence and hard cases

- CORNEA-style skeptical theism asks:
- The heaven objection asks why:
- Which evidential axis asks why suffering falls on infants and animals?



PRACTICE NODE 2 | Part III - Remedial MCQs

- Which conclusion overclaims?



PRACTICE NODE 3 | Set D - Comparative evaluation and answer control

- Which objection most directly tests Hick's soul-making account?



PRACTICE NODE 4 | Set E - Advanced core bridges

Answer: A.

The two categories can jointly structure religion without being synonyms.

- Which synthesis is strongest for a final conclusion?



PRACTICE NODE 5 | Examiner-grade model answer

Why this earns marks: It separates evil from profane, uses Durkheim, Otto/Eliade and Indian soteriologies, answers the functional directive, adds a limitation and closes with a precise verdict.



PRACTICE NODE 6 | Top-answer checklist

- Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?
- Is the doctrine reconstructed rather than merely named?
- Does the final sentence answer the directive?



PRACTICE NODE 7 | Examiner-grade model answer

Why this earns marks: It reconstructs premises, identifies bridge principles, states Plantinga accurately, separates logical from evidential burden and offers a graded conclusion.



PRACTICE NODE 8 | Top-answer checklist

- Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?
- Is the doctrine reconstructed rather than merely named?
- Does the final sentence answer the directive?



PRACTICE NODE 9 | Examiner-grade model answer

[THESIS] Evil creates an omnipotence paradox because an unlimitedly powerful creator appears able to prevent evil, while perfect goodness appears to require prevention.

The paradox weakens once omnipotence is defined as power to do the logically possible and morally coherent, but an evidential residue remains.

Why this earns marks: It directly connects omnipotence to evil, uses the logical-possibility restriction, gives the strongest objection and avoids claiming that freedom solves natural evil.



PRACTICE NODE 10 | Top-answer checklist

- Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?
- Is the doctrine reconstructed rather than merely named?
- Does the final sentence answer the directive?



PRACTICE NODE 11 | Examiner-grade model answer

Why this earns marks: It refuses the false choice between divine and human responsibility, distinguishes causal levels, uses Augustine/Plantinga/process comparison and gives a qualified judgement.



PRACTICE NODE 12 | Top-answer checklist

- Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?
- Is the doctrine reconstructed rather than merely named?
- Does the final sentence answer the directive?



PRACTICE NODE 13 | Examiner-grade model answer

Why this earns marks: It explicates both privation and punishment, uses the blindness example, integrates modern evolutionary criticism, compares alternatives and gives a directive-responsive verdict.



PRACTICE NODE 14 | Top-answer checklist

- Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?
- Is the doctrine reconstructed rather than merely named?
- Does the final sentence answer the directive?



PRACTICE NODE 15 | Examiner-grade model answer

Process theism revises omnipotence: God persuades but cannot coerce finite actualities, buying innocence at the cost of sovereignty.

Open theism revises the settled status of future free acts.

A finite God faces struggle rather than culpable permission.

Advaita (non-dual school) locates evil within the empirical order of avidya (ignorance of reality) and karma (morally consequential action) while ultimate non-duality alters the God-world dualism.

Buddhism, Samkhya (dualist school based on enumerated principles), Mimamsa (inquiry into Vedic duty) and Jainism lack an omnipotent creator defendant, so the question becomes diagnosis of dukkha (suffering or unsatisfactoriness) or bondage.

Nyaya (school of logic and realism) and Visistadvaita (qualified non-dualism) retain a divine governor and therefore must relate karma to just administration.

Why this earns marks: It makes the God-concept the organizing axis, compares preserved and revised attributes, includes accurate Indian diversity and avoids saying non-theism eliminates suffering.



PRACTICE NODE 16 | Top-answer checklist

- Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?
- Is the doctrine reconstructed rather than merely named?
- Does the final sentence answer the directive?



PRACTICE NODE 17 | Examiner-grade model answer

Why this earns marks: It names distinct process thinkers, explains primordial/consequent nature, initial aim and necessary persuasion, and states the exact theological trade-off.



PRACTICE NODE 18 | Top-answer checklist

- Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?
- Is the doctrine reconstructed rather than merely named?
- Does the final sentence answer the directive?

ADVANCED

Optional refinements, second-order objections and controlled answer use.

ADVANCED NODE 1 | Advanced-dossier reconciliation — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

The section dossier marks skeptical theism and horrendous evils as promoted to core because the owner source now teaches CORNEA, representativeness, balancing-off versus defeat, and goodness-to-persons.

Their optional residue is second-order: whether a positive theodicy can be combined consistently with global skepticism, and whether defeat within a sufferer's life is still a general theodicy.

Free-will treatment of natural evil and victim-blaming critiques of karma (morally consequential action) remain high-value comparative refinements, not stand-alone catalogues.



ADVANCED NODE 2 | Advanced Seminar Modules - From Competent to Examiner-Grade

Route marker retained from the learner-v2 source.



ADVANCED NODE 3 | • Modal logic without notation overload — continued 1/4

[THESIS] The logical problem is a question about whether the relevant propositions can be true together in at least one possible world.

The critic alleges that no possible world contains both the classical God and evil; the defender needs only one coherent possibility in which God has a morally sufficient reason to permit evil.

[ARGUMENT] Three modal ideas must be kept separate.

First, logical possibility means that a description contains no contradiction.



ADVANCED NODE 4 | • Modal logic without notation overload — continued 2/4

Second, world feasibility asks whether God can
actualize that description given truths about undetermined creaturely choices.

Third,
actuality asks which world and history obtain.

Plantinga argues at the first two levels.

He
does not infer that the freedom story is the actual divine policy merely because it is possible.

[OBJECTION] The distinction between possible and feasible worlds appears to limit divine power by



ADVANCED NODE 5 | • Modal logic without notation overload — continued 3/4

facts God does not control.

If counterfactuals of freedom are independently true, what grounds
them, and why cannot an omnipotent creator choose better agents or circumstances?

[REPLY] Libertarian freedom precisely denies that God determines the content of the free choice.

The defender can say that creating agents includes accepting truths about how those agents would
freely respond.

The grounding question remains a serious objection to Molinist and feasible-world
accounts, but it is not a proof of contradiction.



ADVANCED NODE 6 | • Modal logic without notation overload — continued 4/4

[QUALIFICATION] In an UPSC answer, modal vocabulary should clarify rather than display technique.

Write: "A logically describable sinless free world may not be strongly actualizable by God if the truth of free creaturely choices is not under divine causal control." Do not use symbols unless they reduce ambiguity.

[VERDICT] Modal analysis is most successful as a negative result: the simple inconsistent-set argument needs more than the bare triad.

It leaves open whether the actual world is a reasonable choice for a perfectly good creator.



ADVANCED NODE 7 | • The moral premises behind the logical problem — continued 1/4

[THESIS] The dispute is not only about divine power.

It is also about the content of goodness.

The premise "a good being eliminates evil" is too strong unless it includes "when elimination does not sacrifice an equal or greater good, violate another's agency, or permit an equal or worse evil."

[ARGUMENT] Ordinary morality permits painful surgery, dangerous education and enforcement of just law when proportionate and necessary.

The theist generalizes: divine permission may be



ADVANCED NODE 8 | • The moral premises behind the logical problem — continued 2/4

morally justified where a good is logically connected with risk.

The critic answers that ordinary

permission is constrained by consent, necessity, proportionality, fair distribution and accountability.

A parent may allow a difficult examination but not torture a child for character.

Therefore "greater good" is not a blank cheque.

[OBJECTION] Applying human moral constraints to God may be anthropomorphic because creatorhood changes the relation between giver of life and creature.



ADVANCED NODE 9 | • The moral premises behind the logical problem — continued 3/4

[REPLY] If divine goodness has no recognizable continuity with moral goodness, the theist loses

the very premise used to praise and worship God.

Analogical predication may allow difference of mode, not reversal of evaluative content.

[QUALIFICATION] This creates a dilemma for extreme skeptical theism.

Too much confidence in human

moral standards makes evil evidentially forceful; too little makes "God is good" thin and removes the basis for positive theodicy.



ADVANCED NODE 10 | • The moral premises behind the logical problem — continued 4/4

[VERDICT] The logical problem is best understood as a stress-test of perfect goodness under the conditions of creator responsibility, not as a mechanical contradiction among three dictionary definitions.



ADVANCED NODE 11 | • Freedom: value, range and responsibility — continued 1/4

[THESIS] Free-will approaches require more than the assertion that freedom is valuable.

They must

specify the kind of freedom, the range of consequences necessary for responsibility, and the distribution of opportunities for meaningful choice.

[ARGUMENT] Libertarian freedom holds that at least some choices are not determined by prior conditions.

Compatibilist freedom identifies acting from one's own reasons without external constraint even if those reasons are causally determined.



ADVANCED NODE 12 | • Freedom: value, range and responsibility — continued 2/4

Plantinga's defence needs a libertarian

relation to God: if God determines the choice, creaturely authorship cannot wholly transfer moral responsibility.

Yet significant freedom need not entail unlimited power to harm.

Human societies

rightly restrict weapons and opportunities for catastrophic wrongdoing while preserving agency.

The critic therefore asks why God permits consequences far beyond what meaningful choice needs.

[OBJECTION] Continuous divine restriction would make the world a moral nursery, obscure causal



ADVANCED NODE 13 | • Freedom: value, range and responsibility — continued 3/4

responsibility and prevent serious cooperation against evil.

[REPLY] The objection supports some regular consequences, not every scale of consequence.

The

theist must explain a threshold: which harms are integral to responsible agency and which are apparently excessive?

[QUALIFICATION] Social and structural evil complicates individualistic freedom.

Poverty,

oppression and institutions are produced through many choices and inherited systems.



ADVANCED NODE 14 | • Freedom: value, range and responsibility — continued 4/4

No single

agent may intend the total harm, yet responsibility is distributed.

A theodicy centered only on

isolated decisions misses this cumulative structure.

[VERDICT] Freedom plausibly explains the possibility of moral fault.

It less clearly explains the

available magnitude of harm, unequal moral opportunity, structural evil and divine non-restraint.



ADVANCED NODE 15 | • Natural evil: autonomy of creation and excess — continued 1/4

[THESIS] A stable natural order is not merely a stage for morality; it is the condition of embodied

life, scientific understanding and purposive action.

Some contemporary formulations describe

creation as having relative autonomy rather than being a theatre of continuous intervention.

[ARGUMENT] Regular tectonics, weather, mutation, immunity and ecological competition have

life-enabling and harm-producing aspects.

A world in which harmful effects vanished whenever they

threatened a person would cease to be cognitively reliable.



ADVANCED NODE 16 | • Natural evil: autonomy of creation and excess — continued 2/4

Agents could not infer causes,

coordinate plans or develop technologies.

This supports a general permission of natural risk.

[OBJECTION] The critic distinguishes law from initial conditions, regularity from intensity, and

ordinary vulnerability from apparently pointless agony.

An omniscient designer could allegedly

choose different constants, safer organisms, earlier warnings or selective interventions without

abolishing order.



ADVANCED NODE 17 | • Natural evil: autonomy of creation and excess — continued 3/4

[REPLY] Whole-system comparison is difficult: changes that remove one harm may remove goods or produce unknown harms.

Complex adaptive systems may require trade-offs that local observers cannot calculate.

[COUNTER-OBJECTION] Difficulty of comparison is epistemic modesty, not positive evidence that the actual balance is optimal.

It blocks confident atheistic inference only to the extent that access is genuinely poor; it also blocks confident theodicy.



ADVANCED NODE 18 | • Natural evil: autonomy of creation and excess — continued 4/4

[VERDICT] Creation-autonomy and law-order accounts explain why a serious world cannot be a hedonistic paradise.

The question of preventable excess remains the central evidential residue.



ADVANCED NODE 19 | • Evolutionary evil and deep time — continued 1/4

[THESIS] Evolutionary history intensifies the problem because pain, predation, parasitism and mass extinction occur over immense pre-human periods.

The data weaken any account that treats natural evil chiefly as punishment for human sin.

[ARGUMENT] Evolution through variation, selection and ecological interaction generates adaptive complexity but also waste, failed organisms and sentient suffering.

A theist may value a creation capable of bringing forth novelty through lawful processes rather than receiving every form by



ADVANCED NODE 20 | • Evolutionary evil and deep time — continued 2/4

direct fiat.

Such fecundity can be a good.

Nevertheless, the process contains beings who cannot understand danger, consent to risk or acquire human-style virtue.

[OBJECTION] Calling evolutionary suffering the price of autonomy treats animals as disposable means.

If God values each sentient creature, a species-level good is insufficient.

[REPLY] A defender may extend eschatological or redemptive goodness to non-human creatures, or



ADVANCED NODE 21 | • Evolutionary evil and deep time — continued 3/4

argue that creaturely value is not exhausted by painless duration.

These proposals are philosophically possible but source-dependent and speculative.

[QUALIFICATION] Karmic rebirth across animal forms supplies a different continuity story, but it can moralize animal pain without accessible evidence of desert.

Jain concern for graded living beings and radical non-violence provides an ethical response even where metaphysical explanation is disputed.



ADVANCED NODE 22 | • Evolutionary evil and deep time — continued 4/4

[VERDICT] Deep time is a fairness test for every theodicy.

A theory that mentions animals only as instruments for human growth is incomplete.



ADVANCED NODE 23 | • Rowe, Draper and cumulative evidence — continued 1/4

[THESIS] The evidential case is strongest when cumulative rather than dependent on one dramatic example.

It combines apparently gratuitous instances with patterns of biological pain, unequal distribution, divine hiddenness and the failure of proposed reasons to cover all classes.

[ARGUMENT] Rowe asks whether at least one instance of intense suffering lacks a justifying connection.

Draper asks a comparative question: is the pattern of pleasure and pain more expected if nature is indifferent than if guided by perfect benevolence?



ADVANCED NODE 24 | • Rowe, Draper and cumulative evidence — continued 2/4

The two approaches can reinforce each other.

Rowe supplies local cases;

Draper supplies pattern comparison.

Neither requires the claim that evil is logically incompatible with God.

[OBJECTION] Theism is not a single bare hypothesis.

It may include freedom, stable law,



ADVANCED NODE 25 | • Rowe, Draper and cumulative evidence — continued 3/4

soul-making, eschatology and independent evidence from religious experience or cosmological arguments.

Evaluating one datum in isolation distorts a cumulative worldview.

[REPLY] Auxiliary theodicies must have independent motivation and predictive discipline.

A view

that adds a new hidden purpose for every counterexample becomes resistant to evidence.

Other

evidence for God can offset evil, but Topic 02 arguments must be weighed rather than presumed.



ADVANCED NODE 26 | • Rowe, Draper and cumulative evidence — continued 4/4

[QUALIFICATION] Do not assign invented numerical priors.

State only the comparative structure:

evidence confirms a hypothesis to the extent that it is more expected on that hypothesis than on its rivals.

[VERDICT] Evidential evil functions as an undercutting and rebutting consideration within a total case.

It rarely yields a stand-alone mathematical conclusion, but it can be philosophically weighty.



ADVANCED NODE 27 | • Skeptical theism: three boundaries — continued 1/3

[THESIS] Skeptical theism is defensible only when bounded epistemically, morally and religiously.

- Epistemic boundary: Human ignorance concerns the full network of divine reasons; it does not imply ignorance of every local good, evil or causal relation.

- Moral boundary: Agents must act on accessible moral reasons.

Unknown divine permission

never authorizes human infliction or neglect.

- Religious boundary: If the view blocks all inference from worldly goods to providence, it cannot selectively block only negative evidence while retaining every positive sign.



ADVANCED NODE 28 | • Skeptical theism: three boundaries — continued 2/3

[ARGUMENT] Wykstra's accessibility principle is plausible when the scale difference between human and divine cognition is relevant.

Bergmann's representativeness concern likewise warns that sampled goods may not exhaust possible goods.

But a complete suspension of inductive judgement would damage ordinary reasoning.

[OBJECTION] The asymmetry between divine and human perspectives may itself justify selective skepticism: evil-permission could involve remote entailments, while some positive religious



ADVANCED NODE 29 | • Skeptical theism: three boundaries — continued 3/3

experiences are direct.

[REPLY] That distinction must be argued case by case.

It cannot be assumed merely to protect a

favoured conclusion.

Moreover, the more opaque divine purposes become, the harder it is to infer

that God is trustworthy in the recognizable moral sense.

[VERDICT] Skeptical theism is best used as a defeater-defeater against overconfident noseenum

reasoning, followed immediately by an affirmation of local moral responsibility.



ADVANCED NODE 30 | • Soul-making under the proportionality test — continued 1/3

[THESIS] Soul-making succeeds for obstacles proportionate to agency and fails when it treats all

suffering as development irrespective of outcome.

[ARGUMENT] A developmental environment needs danger, resistance, uncertainty and other persons'

needs.

These conditions enable courage, patience, compassion and practical wisdom.

Yet formation

requires an agent capable of learning, a challenge within some range of response, and an

opportunity for recovery.



ADVANCED NODE 31 | • Soul-making under the proportionality test — continued 2/3

Horrendous evils can fragment memory, trust and agency.

Infant death

and much animal pain offer no obvious subject of moral formation.

[OBJECTION] Goods may accrue to communities or other persons, and eschatological life may complete development interrupted here.

[REPLY] Community goods do not automatically justify using one person as material for another.

Eschatology can widen the developmental horizon only if the individual sufferer is restored and the evil defeated within that person's good.



ADVANCED NODE 32 | • Soul-making under the proportionality test — continued 3/3

[QUALIFICATION] The distinction between first-order evil and second-order good should never be written as "evil is necessary for good." Some second-order virtues need vulnerability, but the same virtue may be elicited by many degrees of hardship.

Necessity and proportionality require separate argument.

[VERDICT] Hick supplies a powerful account of why a world with no adversity might be morally shallow.

Adams supplies the needed correction: goodness must finally be goodness to persons.



ADVANCED NODE 33 | • Augustine after evolutionary criticism — continued 1/3

[THESIS] Augustine's metaphysical privation claim can survive even if the historical-punitive account of natural evil is rejected.

[ARGUMENT] Corruption remains dependent on an underlying good: disease is malfunction of living systems, cruelty is disorder of agency, injustice is corruption of social relation.

This

ontological point does not require that earthquakes began after a first human sin.

The historical

fall narrative, by contrast, makes empirical and moral claims about original perfection,



ADVANCED NODE 34 | • Augustine after evolutionary criticism — continued 2/3

inherited disorder and punishment.

[OBJECTION] Separating privation from fall may save a fragment while abandoning the theodicy.

Even if evil is ontologically parasitic, God creates the subjects and conditions in which privation occurs.

[REPLY] The defender can combine privation with finite creation and free development: a created world is good yet not divine or incapable of defect.

This avoids dualism without claiming that

every natural evil punishes sin.



ADVANCED NODE 35 | • Augustine after evolutionary criticism — continued 3/3

[COUNTER-OBJECTION] If defect is an inevitable condition of finite being, either God cannot create without evil or chooses a vulnerable order.

The classical question returns at the level of creation.

[VERDICT] Use Augustine in layers.

Privation is the strongest philosophical layer; defective freedom is strong for moral evil; universal punishment and a historical cosmic fall carry the heaviest burden.



ADVANCED NODE 36 | • Process theology compared with voluntary self-limitation — continued 1/4

[THESIS] Process non-coercion and classical kenotic self-limitation must be distinguished by modality.

In a self-limitation view, God possesses unilateral power but refrains for the sake of freedom or relationship.

In Griffin-style process thought, such unilateral coercion is not a metaphysical possibility.

[ARGUMENT] The distinction changes responsibility.

Voluntary restraint still permits the



ADVANCED NODE 37 | • Process theology compared with voluntary self-limitation — continued 2/4

question, "Why did God not make an exception here?" Necessary non-coercion answers that no exception was available.

It therefore gives process thought a cleaner innocence claim but a greater assurance problem.

A God who voluntarily risks creation may remain sovereign; a process

God participates in a field of distributed creativity.

[OBJECTION] Process thought may redefine divine power until God resembles one influential cause among others.



ADVANCED NODE 38 | • Process theology compared with voluntary self-limitation — continued 3/4

[REPLY] Hartshornean and process accounts distinguish supreme relational or persuasive power from finite power.

God offers the best possibility to every occasion and perfectly receives all value; supremacy need not mean monopoly.

[QUALIFICATION] The answer must state that Whitehead's dipolar terminology, Hartshorne's critique of omnipotence and Griffin's theodicy are related but not interchangeable.

Do not attribute every

later theological conclusion directly to Whitehead.



ADVANCED NODE 39 | • Process theology compared with voluntary self-limitation — continued 4/4

[VERDICT] Process thought gives the most systematic non-classical response to natural evil, but its success depends on whether worship and hope require guaranteed control.



ADVANCED NODE 40 | • Karma (morally consequential action): desert, causation and social ethics — continued 1/4

[THESIS] Karma can be interpreted as desert, impersonal moral causation, character formation or bondage mechanics.

The ethical evaluation changes with the interpretation.

[ARGUMENT] A strict desert reading says present suffering is proportionate consequence of prior wrongdoing.

An impersonal-causation reading treats deeds as producing tendencies without a divine judge.

A formative reading emphasizes how action shapes character and future possibility.



ADVANCED NODE 41 | • Karma (morally consequential action): desert, causation and social ethics — continued 2/4

Jain

karmic matter gives a more literal bondage mechanism, while Buddhist dependent continuity denies a permanent owner.

Nyaya (school of logic and realism) adds an intelligent allocator;

Mimamsa (inquiry into Vedic duty) can retain ritual efficacy

without creatorhood.

[OBJECTION] Without memory, transparent proportionality or a stable person, retribution seems unfair.



ADVANCED NODE 42 | • Karma (morally consequential action): desert, causation and social ethics — continued 3/4

Beginninglessness avoids a first-cause regress only by denying a first temporal point; it

does not show why the system is morally good.

Socially, observers may infer desert from

misfortune and withhold reform.

[REPLY] Memory is not the sole ground of responsibility even within one life, and causal

continuity can support concern.

More importantly, no school licenses a bystander to know a

victim's hidden karmic history.



ADVANCED NODE 43 | • Karma (morally consequential action): desert, causation and social ethics — continued 4/4

Compassion, dana, ahimsa (non-violence) and assistance are themselves morally

required actions.

[VERDICT] Use karma as a comparative model of trans-life moral causation, never as a warrant for

explaining a particular victim.

Its strongest feature is distribution; its greatest risk is

retrospective moralization.



ADVANCED NODE 44 | • Advaita (non-dual school) and the reality-status objection — continued 1/3

[THESIS] Advaita changes the problem by distinguishing empirical experience from ultimate

non-duality, but it cannot responsibly answer suffering with the slogan "the world is unreal."

[ARGUMENT] At the empirical level, persons, Isvara (Lord or personal God), karma (morally consequential action), dharma (duty or sustaining moral order), ignorance and suffering are operative.

Knowledge removes the fundamental misidentification of self with finite body-mind and

reveals non-dual Brahman (ultimate reality).

At the ultimate level, no independent evil principle confronts Brahman.

The classical creator-versus-evil duality is therefore not final.



ADVANCED NODE 45 | • Advaita (non-dual school) and the reality-status objection — continued 2/3

[OBJECTION] If empirical suffering is sublated, the view may appear to trivialize victims and make moral action provisional.

[REPLY] Empirical validity is sufficient for duties, compassion, discipline and liberation practice before realization.

Sublatability does not mean non-occurrence at its operative level.

Dream pain can be real to the dreamer without being ultimate, though this analogy must not be used pastorally to dismiss actual trauma.

[QUALIFICATION] Ramanuja's critique is relevant: if the world and selves are real modes dependent



ADVANCED NODE 46 | • Advaita (non-dual school) and the reality-status objection — continued 3/3

on Brahman (ultimate reality), their suffering cannot be assigned merely a lower ontological status.

Visistadvaita (qualified non-dualism)

therefore retains a more direct theistic governance problem alongside karma (morally consequential action) and grace.

[VERDICT] Advaita dissolves the ultimate metaphysical dualism but leaves an empirical ethical and soteriological problem that must be answered through knowledge, duty and compassion.



ADVANCED NODE 47 | • Buddhist and Samkhya (dualist school based on enumerated principles) diagnoses compared — continued 1/4

[THESIS] Buddhism and Samkhya both avoid a creator theodicy but disagree radically about self and the cause of bondage.

[ARGUMENT] Samkhya locates suffering in purusha (pure conscious self)'s apparent identification with prakriti (primordial material nature)'s evolutes.

Discriminative knowledge separates consciousness from material-nature activity, culminating in kaivalya.

Buddhism denies a permanent purusha and analyses dukkha (suffering or unsatisfactoriness) through dependent origination, impermanence, craving and ignorance.



ADVANCED NODE 48 | • Buddhist and Samkhya (dualist school based on enumerated principles) diagnoses compared — continued 2/4

Cessation is not isolation of a substantial witness but ending the conditions that sustain appropriation and suffering.

[OBJECTION] Removing God avoids culpability but may not explain why the beginningless causal order has its painful character.

Samkhya must explain the conjunction of radically different principles;

Buddhism must explain responsibility and continuity without self.

[REPLY] Both systems present the "why" as a mistaken demand for a first creator-cause and redirect



ADVANCED NODE 49 | • Buddhist and Samkhya (dualist school based on enumerated principles) diagnoses compared — continued 3/4

attention to operative conditions and liberation.

A causal diagnosis can be sufficient for practice even without a cosmic justification.

[QUALIFICATION] This is a reframing, not a victory by default.

Existential pain, compassion and fairness remain, while the logical inconsistent triad disappears.

[VERDICT] Creatorless systems demonstrate that the problem of evil is not coextensive with the problem of suffering.



ADVANCED NODE 50 | • Buddhist and Samkhya (dualist school based on enumerated principles) diagnoses compared — continued 4/4

They exchange theodicy for diagnosis and soteriology.



ADVANCED NODE 51 | • Protest, lament and moral knowledge — continued 1/3

[THESIS] Protest is philosophically important because it treats the negative moral appearance of

suffering as knowledge-bearing rather than as a defect of faith.

[ARGUMENT] Job's protest resists friends who infer guilt from suffering.

Ivan Karamazov refuses

to endorse a harmony that uses innocent agony.

Camus makes solidarity and revolt an ethical

answer without metaphysical reconciliation.

These positions differ, but all reject the movement



ADVANCED NODE 52 | • Protest, lament and moral knowledge — continued 2/3

from "a total explanation may exist" to "the sufferer should accept our explanation."

[OBJECTION] Protest without metaphysical resolution may express emotion rather than answer the

truth question.

[REPLY] Moral perception is part of the evidence.

A theory that can preserve consistency only by

erasing the prima facie wrongness of cruelty has changed the meaning of goodness.

Protest also

generates practical reasons to resist avoidable evil.



ADVANCED NODE 53 | • Protest, lament and moral knowledge — continued 3/3

[QUALIFICATION] Anti-theodicy should not be represented as the claim that no meaning, redemption

or religious response is possible.

Its central objection is to comprehensive third-person

justification and instrumentalization.

[VERDICT] Protest is not a logical refutation of theism, but it is a constraint on what may count

as a morally adequate theodicy.



ADVANCED NODE 54 | • Pastoral reason and philosophical restraint — continued 1/4

[THESIS] The order appropriate to an examination answer is not always the order appropriate at a hospital bed, disaster site or bereavement.

Philosophical competence includes knowing when an explanation is morally mistimed.

[ARGUMENT] A sufferer may need safety, truthful presence, lament and practical assistance before causal or theological interpretation.

Offering karma (morally consequential action), punishment or soul-making as a diagnosis of a particular person's suffering exceeds available evidence and can add moral injury.



ADVANCED NODE 55 | • Pastoral reason and philosophical restraint — continued 2/4

Prayer can include protest; trust can coexist with uncertainty; religious communities can embody solidarity without claiming a hidden plan.

[OBJECTION] Refusing explanation may leave religious belief cognitively empty when it is most challenged.

[REPLY] Restraint is not permanent evasion.

General philosophical accounts can be assessed in appropriate contexts.



ADVANCED NODE 56 | • Pastoral reason and philosophical restraint — continued 3/4

The immediate moral duty is not identical with the later intellectual task.

[QUALIFICATION] The same rule protects against secular triumphalism.

One should not use a person's trauma as an occasion to score an atheistic conclusion either.

Victim-centered reason asks what the evidence supports and what the situation ethically permits.

[VERDICT] The practical implication of the problem of evil is active compassion under epistemic



ADVANCED NODE 57 | • Pastoral reason and philosophical restraint — continued 4/4

humility.

A theory that excuses preventable harm fails regardless of its abstract elegance.



ADVANCED NODE 58 | • Full comparative audit grid — continued 1/2

| Test | Freedom | Soul-making | Augustine | Leibniz | Process | Karma (morally consequential action) | Buddhism |

| --- | --- | --- | --- | --- | --- | --- | --- |

| Primary burden | Compatibility | Actual purpose | Origin/status | Optimal totality | Revised power | Distribution | Diagnosis |

| Moral evil | Strong | Moderate | Strong | Systemic | Distributed | Prior agency | Craving/action |

| Natural evil | Weak alone | Law/development | Punitive strain | Systemic | Stronger | Trans-life | Conditioned |

| Animal suffering | Weak | Weak | Severe strain | Aggregate risk | Included | Moralization risk | Included as dukkha (suffering or unsatisfactoriness) |

| Victim focus | Indirect | At risk | Punitive | Aggregate | Solidarity | Blame risk | Compassion/path |

| Afterlife role | Optional | Usually central | Judgement | Harmony | Uncertain | Rebirth/liberation | Rebirth/cessation |



ADVANCED NODE 59 | • Full comparative audit grid — continued 2/2

| Attribute cost | None formally | Epistemic distance | Fall burden | Best-world claim | Omnipotence revised | Varies | No creator |

| Best use | Logical PYQ | Development comparison | 2023 PYQ | Modal comparison | 2025 PYQ | Indian parity | Reframing |

[VERDICT] No theory dominates every axis.

The examiner rewards explicit trade-offs: what class of evil is covered, what divine attribute is preserved, what moral cost arises and what residue remains.



ADVANCED NODE 60 | • Essay laboratory - Is evil evidence against God or against a concept of God? — continued 1/4

[THESIS] Evil first tests a concept of God and only then contributes evidence about whether any being answering to that concept exists.

If "God" means an omnipotent, omniscient and perfectly good creator, apparently preventable suffering bears directly on the concept's instantiation.

If God is finite, processual, impersonal or not a creator, the inference changes.

[ARGUMENT] The conceptual stage asks which attributes generate expectations.

Perfect goodness



ADVANCED NODE 61 | • Essay laboratory - Is evil evidence against God or against a concept of God? — continued 2/4

creates an expectation of opposition to evil; knowledge creates awareness; power creates capacity; creatorhood creates responsibility for the framework.

The evidential stage compares those expectations with the world.

A process God predicts struggle and partial achievement more readily than classical control.

Advaita (non-dual school) predicts an empirically operative but ultimately sublatale order.

Buddhism predicts conditioned suffering without a providential distribution.



ADVANCED NODE 62 | • Essay laboratory - Is evil evidence against God or against a concept of God? — continued 3/4

Each view must be

tested against what it actually asserts.

[OBJECTION] This method lets believers escape evidence by revising God whenever a difficulty arises.

[REPLY] Revision is legitimate only if independently motivated and if its religious cost is paid openly.

An ad hoc finite God introduced solely to avoid evil has weak explanatory value.

Process



ADVANCED NODE 63 | • Essay laboratory - Is evil evidence against God or against a concept of God? — continued 4/4

thought, by contrast, offers a wider metaphysics of power and becoming, though that metaphysics is contestable.

[VERDICT] Evil does not address an empty word.

It confirms or disconfirms profiles.

The strongest

answer therefore moves in the order concept -> expectation -> evidence -> revision cost.



ADVANCED NODE 64 | • Essay laboratory - Could God create virtue without suffering? — continued 1/4

[THESIS] Some virtue logically requires vulnerability, but it does not follow that the actual quantity and distribution of suffering is required.

[ARGUMENT] Courage needs perceived danger, compassion needs another's need, forgiveness presupposes wrong, and responsibility needs consequential action.

These are relation-dependent goods.

A world containing them cannot be wholly insulated from harm.

Yet virtues differ:



ADVANCED NODE 65 | • Essay laboratory - Could God create virtue without suffering? — continued 2/4

creativity, friendship, gratitude and understanding do not require atrocity.

Even danger-dependent

virtues may require only bounded challenge.

The critic can therefore grant soul-making while denying that horrors are necessary.

[OBJECTION] The total network of virtues, histories and free relations may require risks that no local observer can calculate.

[REPLY] This possibility creates humility but not justification.



ADVANCED NODE 66 | • Essay laboratory - Could God create virtue without suffering? — continued 3/4

The theist should avoid the

universal claim that every evil is necessary and defend only a general risk structure.

Adams's

defeat condition must handle cases that exceed ordinary formation.

[QUALIFICATION] The question "Could God create virtue directly?" also concerns authenticity.

Implanted dispositions may be good qualities, but achieved virtues include a person's authorship and history.

That distinction supports development without proving every route to development



ADVANCED NODE 67 | • Essay laboratory - Could God create virtue without suffering? — continued 4/4

morally permissible.

[VERDICT] Soul-making explains why a frictionless world may lack important goods; proportionality

and goodness-to-persons decide whether the explanation reaches actual horrors.



ADVANCED NODE 68 | • Essay laboratory - Is divine permission equivalent to causation? — continued 1/4

[THESIS] Permission and causation are not identical, but a creator's permission can still carry responsibility where prevention is easy, knowledge complete and the stakes grave.

[ARGUMENT] A human wrongdoer can be the direct efficient cause of moral evil.

God, on classical

theism, causes the agent and sustaining order but does not determine the free choice.

This supports

derivative creaturely culpability.

Nevertheless, knowingly selecting and sustaining a world



ADVANCED NODE 69 | • Essay laboratory - Is divine permission equivalent to causation? — continued 2/4

creates a responsibility of framework and permission.

Moral analysis therefore needs at least

three levels: authorship of the act, design of available powers and consequences, and decision

whether to intervene.

[OBJECTION] If God intervened whenever misuse became serious, creaturely action would not be real.

[REPLY] Responsibility does not require unlimited consequence.

Legal and social systems constrain

harm while retaining agency.



ADVANCED NODE 70 | • Essay laboratory - Is divine permission equivalent to causation? — continued 3/4

The theist must identify why divine restraint is more limited than

responsible human restraint should be.

[QUALIFICATION] Process thought changes the third level by denying unilateral prevention.

Karma (morally consequential action)

systems distribute responsibility across a life-series.

Non-creator systems remove framework

selection by God but retain causal questions about bondage.

[VERDICT] The 2022 PYQ is best answered through layered rather than exclusive responsibility:



ADVANCED NODE 71 | • Essay laboratory - Is divine permission equivalent to causation? — continued 4/4

human authorship can be real while divine permission remains philosophically assessable.



ADVANCED NODE 72 | • Essay laboratory - Can eschatology repair theodicy? — continued 1/3

[THESIS] Eschatology can prevent a life from being finally defeated by evil, but future bliss is

not automatically a moral warrant for earlier permission.

[ARGUMENT] Hick needs eventual fulfilment because earthly opportunities are radically unequal.

Adams needs a good powerful enough to defeat horrors within the participant's life.

Augustine's

judgement framework seeks cosmic moral order.

These uses differ: completion of development,

personal redemption and retributive balance are not interchangeable.



ADVANCED NODE 73 | • Essay laboratory - Can eschatology repair theodicy? — continued 2/3

[OBJECTION] If eternal good infinitely exceeds finite suffering, the total life is good.

[REPLY] Aggregate outweighing does not settle consent, use and dignity.

It would be wrong to harm

a person deliberately merely because one later supplies a larger benefit.

The theist needs an

internal relation between redemption and the suffered evil, or a reason why permission respected

the person throughout.

[QUALIFICATION] Eschatology is a substantive religious commitment, not publicly established by



ADVANCED NODE 74 | • Essay laboratory - Can eschatology repair theodicy? — continued 3/3

the problem of evil itself.

It may belong in a cumulative theology, but should be labelled rather

than smuggled into a supposedly neutral proof.

[VERDICT] Eschatology is strongest as a theory of defeat and hope, weaker as a retroactive licence.

It deepens the response only when it remains victim-centered.



ADVANCED NODE 75 | • Essay laboratory - Does prayer intensify the problem? — continued 1/3

[THESIS] Petitionary prayer can intensify evil's evidential problem because traditions portray God

as able and willing to respond, while many urgent petitions appear unanswered.

It can also

transform the existential response through lament, solidarity and moral mobilization.

[ARGUMENT] If God sometimes prevents harm in response to prayer, selective non-prevention demands

an account of distribution.

If God never changes outcomes, petition requires reinterpretation.

Stable-law defenders may say prayer is not a mechanism for suspending causation; it can align the



ADVANCED NODE 76 | • Essay laboratory - Does prayer intensify the problem? — continued 2/3

agent with divine purpose and community action.

Protest prayer preserves relationship without

pretending to understand permission.

[OBJECTION] Unanswered prayer is merely another instance of limited human perspective.

[REPLY] That answer is available but costly.

It makes claims of answered providence harder to

interpret and can render petitionary expectations opaque.

A consistent view must treat positive



ADVANCED NODE 77 | • Essay laboratory - Does prayer intensify the problem? — continued 3/3

and negative cases with the same epistemic standard.

[QUALIFICATION] This is a bounded link to religious experience, reason and faith.

The Problem of

Evil owner uses prayer only to test lived implications, not to provide a full theory of prayer.

[VERDICT] Prayer does not solve evil.

At its best it refuses isolation, voices protest and

generates compassionate action without claiming privileged knowledge of hidden reasons.



ADVANCED NODE 78 | • Essay laboratory - The relation between evil and divine hiddenness — continued 1/3

[THESIS] Hiddenness aggravates suffering when a loving God could provide unmistakable presence, guidance or consolation without removing all freedom.

[ARGUMENT] Hick values epistemic distance because overwhelming awareness might compromise free relationship and development.

The critic distinguishes coercive display from adequate availability:

a parent can remain non-coercive while being recognizably present to a terrified child.

Sincere

nonbelief and divine silence during horror therefore add an interpersonal dimension to evidential



ADVANCED NODE 79 | • Essay laboratory - The relation between evil and divine hiddenness — continued 2/3

evil.

[OBJECTION] Religious growth may require trust under ambiguity, and divine presence may occur in forms the sufferer cannot presently recognize.

[REPLY] Again, possibility is not proportionality.

Some ambiguity may preserve freedom; extreme absence may destroy the very trust and agency soul-making requires.

The distribution of religious awareness becomes relevant.



ADVANCED NODE 80 | • Essay laboratory - The relation between evil and divine hiddenness — continued 3/3

[QUALIFICATION] Do not turn this section into a full hiddenness essay or assert that hiddenness is itself always evil.

Use it as an auxiliary pressure on epistemic-distance explanations.

[VERDICT] Hiddenness shows that the problem concerns not only prevention of pain but the quality of divine relationship under pain.



ADVANCED NODE 81 | • Essay laboratory - Can theism learn from non-theistic traditions? — continued 1/3

[THESIS] Non-theistic traditions cannot be imported as ready-made theodicies, but they can correct theism's tendency to prioritize cosmic justification over diagnosis and practice.

[ARGUMENT] Buddhism starts from dukkha (suffering or unsatisfactoriness), traces conditions and prescribes a path.

Jainism links bondage to disciplined non-violence.

Samkhya (dualist school based on enumerated principles) diagnoses misidentification and seeks discriminative release.

These approaches ask what sustains suffering and how agency can respond, without first



ADVANCED NODE 82 | • Essay laboratory - Can theism learn from non-theistic traditions? — continued 2/3

vindicating a creator.

Theistic traditions can likewise make lament, compassion and prevention

central even while retaining questions of providence.

[OBJECTION] Borrowing practice while retaining creator belief avoids the distinctive metaphysical challenge.

[REPLY] The challenge remains; learning at the practical level is not a logical solution.

It is a

test of whether a proposed belief produces responsible action.



ADVANCED NODE 83 | • Essay laboratory - Can theism learn from non-theistic traditions? — continued 3/3

Comparative philosophy need not

erase doctrinal difference to identify shared ethical insight.

[QUALIFICATION] Karma (morally consequential action) should not be treated as the universal bridge.

Buddhist no-self, Jaina jiva (individual living self),

Samkhya (dualist school based on enumerated principles) purusha (pure conscious self) and Vedantic (pertaining to the school based on the culmination of sacred revelation) selves differ fundamentally.

[VERDICT] The most fruitful comparison is functional and critical: creator-theism supplies a

permission problem; non-creator systems supply alternative causal and soteriological grammars;

each can be evaluated for compassion, responsibility and explanatory cost.



ADVANCED NODE 84 | • Essay laboratory - Final position options — continued 1/4

[THESIS] A candidate need not claim a total solution.

A reasoned final position can take one of

four forms, provided its cost is explicit.

- Classical preservation: Free will, stable law, soul-making and eschatological defeat jointly make theism coherent and not unreasonable.

Cost: multiple auxiliary commitments and a residue of apparently gratuitous evil.

- Epistemically modest preservation: Plantinga defeats contradiction; skeptical theism blocks



ADVANCED NODE 85 | • Essay laboratory - Final position options — continued 2/4

overconfident induction; no complete theodicy is claimed.

Cost: opacity of goodness and providence.

- Non-classical revision: Process or finite theism reduces culpability through distributed power.

Cost: weakened sovereignty and assurance.

- Non-theistic reframing: Buddhism, Jainism or Samkhya (dualist school based on enumerated principles) removes the creator defendant and prioritizes diagnosis and liberation.



ADVANCED NODE 86 | • Essay laboratory - Final position options — continued 3/4

Cost: unresolved questions of causal order, identity or

ultimate why.

[ARGUMENT] These are not equal answers to one fixed question.

Each changes premises, explanatory

burdens and religious practices.

The examiner should be shown exactly what has been preserved,

revised or abandoned.

[VERDICT] The most defensible synthetic judgement is that strict logical incompatibility is not



ADVANCED NODE 87 | • Essay laboratory - Final position options — continued 4/4

established, evidential evil remains substantial, and moral protest limits every universal

theodicy.

Philosophical integrity requires continued action against suffering rather than

premature closure.

EXAM CONVERSION

Final comparison lens, PYQ route map and marks-wise answer spine.

COMPARISON LENS

9.5 Epistemic humility versus skepticism -> [THESIS] Humility recognizes limited perspective. Skepticism becomes costly when it blocks all moral assessment, providential inference or positive religious knowledge.

Session 10 - Comparative Synthesis and Practical Implications

10.1 Multi-axis comparison -> | View | Divine attributes | Cause/account | Natural/animal evil | Distribution | Ethical cost |

Set C - Indian comparison

Set D - Comparative evaluation and answer control -> • Which objection most directly tests Hick's soul-making account?

- Process theology compared with voluntary self-limitation -> [THESIS] Process non-coercion and classical kenotic self-limitation must be distinguished by
- Buddhist and Samkhya (dualist school based on enumerated principles) diagnoses compared -> [THESIS] Buddhism and Samkhya both avoid a creator theodicy but disagree radically about self and
- Full comparative audit grid -> | Test | Freedom | Soul-making | Augustine | Leibniz | Process | Karma (morally consequential action) | Buddhism |

B. Distinctions that earn marks -> | Do not collapse | Precise distinction |

D. Indian comparison bank -> • Nyaya (school of logic and realism): theistic karmic administration; still faces painful-mechanism question.



PYQ ROUTE MAP

Part I - All Verified PYQs

PYQ 1 - 2019, Q6(b), 15 marks

PYQ 2 - 2020, Q6(b), 15 marks

PYQ 3 - 2021, Q5(e), 10 marks

PYQ 4 - 2022, Q6(c), 15 marks

PYQ 5 - 2023, Q8(a), 20 marks

PYQ 6 - 2024, Q6(c), 15 marks

PYQ 7 - 2025, Q6(b), 15 marks

F. Seven PYQ routes -> • 2019: sacred/profane boundary plus evil as soteriological predicament; profane is not evil.



ANSWER-WRITING SPINE

Top-answer checklist -> • Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?

Examiner-grade model answer -> [THESIS] Evil creates an omnipotence paradox because an unlimitedly powerful creator appears able to prevent evil, while perfect goodness appears to require prevention. The paradox weakens once omnipotence is defined as power to do the logically possible and morally coherent, but an evidential residue remains.

Top-answer checklist -> • Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?

Examiner-grade model answer -> Why this earns marks: It refuses the false choice between divine and human responsibility, distinguishes causal levels, uses Augustine/Plantinga/process comparison and gives a qualified judgement.

Top-answer checklist -> • Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?

Examiner-grade model answer -> Why this earns marks: It explicates both privation and punishment, uses the blindness example, integrates modern evolutionary criticism, compares alternatives and gives a directive-responsive verdict.

Top-answer checklist -> • Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?

Examiner-grade model answer -> Process theism revises omnipotence: God persuades but cannot coerce finite actualities, buying innocence at the cost of sovereignty. Open theism revises the settled status of future free acts. A finite God faces struggle rather than culpable permission. Advaita (non-dual school) locates evil within the empirical order of avidya (ignorance of reality) and karma (morally consequential action) while ultimate non-duality alters the God-world dualism. Buddhism, Samkhya (dualist school based on enumerated principles), Mimamsa (inquiry into Vedic duty) and Jainism lack an omnipotent creator defendant, so the question becomes diagnosis of dukkha (suffering or unsatisfactoriness) or bondage. Nyaya (school of logic and realism) and Visistadvaita (qualified non-dualism) retain a divine governor and therefore must relate karma to just administration.

Top-answer checklist -> • Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?

Examiner-grade model answer -> Why this earns marks: It names distinct process thinkers, explains primordial/consequent nature, initial aim and necessary persuasion, and states the exact theological trade-off.

Top-answer checklist -> • Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?

G. 10/15/20-mark answer spines -> 10 marks:



D-R-O-R-V EXAM SEQUENCE

Define the exact issue.

Reconstruct the doctrine or argument step by step.

Present the strongest named objection.

State the best reply or qualification.

Deliver a graded verdict that directly answers the directive.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINES — CORRESPONDING FLOWCHART STAGES

Each highlighted sentence is complete, exam-ready and linked to its major learner-v2 subtopic. Definition cards explicitly identify the recommended opening definition.

BASIC STAGE

BASIC Roadmap	
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	High-value transition: PYQ priority: Very high. The audited Paper II corpus contains 7 primary-owned questions, one in every year from 2019 through 2025 and none in 2018.
BASIC Session 1 - Conceptual Method: What Problem Is Being Asked?	
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	Major criticism: The problem of evil is not one argument but a family of challenges generated by the relation among a divine profile, the facts of suffering and wrongdoing, and norms governing what a good agent would permit.
BASIC 1.1 The object of analysis	
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	Recommended opening definition: The problem of evil is not one argument but a family of challenges generated by the relation among a divine profile, the facts of suffering and wrongdoing, and norms governing what a good agent would permit.
BASIC 1.2 Four distinct challenges	
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	Major criticism: A modal defence can answer the first while leaving the other three largely untouched.
BASIC 1.3 Defence, theodicy, explanation and justification	
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	Major reply: Compatibility is weaker than probability; probability is weaker than full explanation; explanation is different from moral justification.
BASIC 1.4 Kinds of evil	
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	Recommended opening definition: Suffering is an experiential harm; wrongdoing is a culpable act or disposition.

BASIC | Session 2 - Classical Formulation and Mackie's Logical Problem**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Major criticism: The familiar questions - whether God is willing but unable, able but unwilling, or both able and willing while evil exists - are commonly labelled the Epicurean paradox.

BASIC | 2.1 Epicurean attribution caution, Hume and Mackie**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: The familiar questions - whether God is willing but unable, able but unwilling, or both able and willing while evil exists - are commonly labelled the Epicurean paradox.

BASIC | 2.2 Formal reconstruction**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Core argument: Premises 4 and 5 are not mere definitions.

BASIC | 2.3 What counts as a reply?**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Major reply: The theist need not show why every actual evil occurs in order to defeat a bare contradiction.

BASIC | 2.4 Omnipotence paradox and attribute control**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Major criticism: Omnipotence means power to do what is logically possible, not power to instantiate contradictions.

BASIC | Session 3 - Plantinga's Free Will Defence**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Major reply: The defence is strongest for moral evil.

BASIC | 3.1 Significant freedom and possible worlds**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: Alvin Plantinga's Free Will Defence aims at the logical problem.

BASIC | 3.2 Transworld depravity accurately stated**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: Transworld depravity is not the claim that every person is maximally wicked or always chooses evil.

BASIC | 3.3 Natural evil extension and residual limits**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Recommended opening definition: The defence is strongest for moral evil.

BASIC | Session 4 - Evidential Evil: Rowe, Probability and Skeptical Theism**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Recommended opening definition: Evidential force depends on a noseum move: "We see no justifying reason; therefore there probably is none." Such reasoning is strong when observers would likely detect the relevant reason if it existed, as when looking for an elephant in a small room.

BASIC | 4.1 Rowe and apparently gratuitous suffering**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: William Rowe's evidential argument grants that God and evil may be logically compatible.

BASIC | 4.2 The noseum inference**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Core argument: Evidential force depends on a noseum move: "We see no justifying reason; therefore there probably is none." Such reasoning is strong when observers would likely detect the relevant reason if it existed, as when looking for an elephant in a small room.

BASIC | 4.3 Draper and conceptual Bayesian framing**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Recommended opening definition: Paul Draper's evidential strategy, where used, compares hypotheses: the biological distribution of pain and pleasure may be less surprising on an indifferent naturalistic hypothesis than on perfect theism.

BASIC | 4.4 Scale, distribution, intensity and hiddenness**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: Divine hiddenness is a bounded cross-link, not a substitute topic.

BASIC | 4.5 Skeptical theism**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Recommended opening definition: Skeptical theists challenge our entitlement to infer from "no reason we can see" to "probably no reason." Wykstra's CORNEA-style principle asks whether, if the proposed good existed, it is reasonable to expect that we would discern it.

BASIC | Session 5 - Classical Theodicies and Defences**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Major reply: Created being is good insofar as it has being; evil is not a positive substance made by God but a privation, corruption or disorder of a due good.

BASIC | 5.1 Augustine: privation, fall and free will**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Recommended opening definition: Augustine treats evil as a privation of good arising through created freedom, not as a positive substance created by God.

BASIC | 5.2 Irenaeus and Hick: developmental soul-making**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Recommended opening definition: Soul-making theodicy presents an epistemically distant and law-governed world as the arena in which immature persons develop virtue.

BASIC | 5.3 Leibniz: best possible world**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Recommended opening definition: Leibniz argues that a perfect God actualizes the best feasible world as a total order, not a world containing no local evil.

BASIC | 5.4 Greater-good, law-governed order and Swinburne-style responsibility**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: A regular world is necessary for knowledge, prediction, action and moral responsibility.

BASIC | 5.5 Punishment, discipline and providence - use with caution**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: Retributive punishment may explain a wrongdoer's suffering only where guilt, proportionality and legitimate authority are established.

BASIC | Session 6 - Non-Classical Theisms and Revised Divine Attributes**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Recommended opening definition: Whitehead is the metaphysical source; Hartshorne argues against classical omnipotence; David Ray Griffin develops process theodicy; John Cobb systematizes process theology.

BASIC | 6.1 Process theodicy: Whitehead, Hartshorne, Griffin and Cobb**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: Whitehead is the metaphysical source; Hartshorne argues against classical omnipotence; David Ray Griffin develops process theodicy; John Cobb systematizes process theology.

BASIC | 6.2 Finite God, open theism and Molinism**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Recommended opening definition: Revising an attribute can dissolve the original inconsistent set, but it does not make suffering disappear.

BASIC | Session 7 - Existential Evil, Protest and Horrendous Evils**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Recommended opening definition: Existential approaches ask not only whether a proposition is coherent but what stance is humanly and morally possible before suffering.

BASIC | 7.1 Job, Kierkegaard, Dostoevsky and Camus**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: Existential approaches ask not only whether a proposition is coherent but what stance is humanly and morally possible before suffering.

BASIC | 7.2 Holocaust and post-Holocaust caution**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: The moral danger is instrumentalization: treating victims' suffering as a means to another person's virtue, historical progress or cosmic beauty.

BASIC | 7.3 Marilyn McCord Adams and horrendous evils**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Recommended opening definition: The framework deepens soul-making, but it also shows why no general-purpose developmental story is sufficient for horrors.

BASIC | Session 8 - Indian and Non-Western Frameworks**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: Karma (morally consequential action) is structurally strong on distribution but morally dangerous when converted into retrospective certainty about a victim.

BASIC | 8.1 Method: no single "Indian solution"**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Recommended opening definition: Indian traditions do not share one answer because they disagree about creator, self, world, karma (morally consequential action) and liberation.

BASIC | 8.2 Karma and rebirth**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Recommended opening definition: Nyaya (school of logic and realism): Ishvara (Lord or personal God) can administer unseen karmic potency and cosmic order; God is not an arbitrary author but a just allocator.

BASIC | 8.3 Critiques of karma**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Recommended opening definition: Karma (morally consequential action) is structurally strong on distribution but morally dangerous when converted into retrospective certainty about a victim.

BASIC | 8.4 Buddhism: dukkha and dependent origination**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Recommended opening definition: [OBJECTION] A diagnostic path may not answer why the world contains horrific suffering or why causal continuity is morally just without a stable self.

BASIC | 8.5 Jainism**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: Jainism treats karma (morally consequential action) as subtle material bondage adhering to jiva (individual living self) through passion and action.

BASIC | 8.6 Bhakti and providence**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: Bhakti traditions vary. Relevant responses include trust, surrender, lament, grace, divine companionship and service.

BASIC | Session 9 - Hard Cases and Meta-Level Critiques**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: Animal suffering is a central evidential challenge because predation, disease, parasitism and extinction precede human agency and often seem unrelated to moral growth.

BASIC | 9.1 Animal suffering and evolutionary evil**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Recommended opening definition: Animal suffering is a central evidential challenge because predation, disease, parasitism and extinction precede human agency and often seem unrelated to moral growth.

BASIC | 9.2 Free will and heaven**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: Heaven pressures but does not automatically refute freedom-based accounts; it forces a temporal and developmental explanation.

BASIC | 9.3 Natural laws and preventable excess**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: A law-governed order explains regular vulnerability.

BASIC | 9.4 Afterlife compensation versus justification**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: Compensation gives a later good; justification shows permission was morally acceptable; defeat integrates the evil within the sufferer's good.

BASIC | 9.5 Epistemic humility versus skepticism**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: The strongest bounded position is asymmetric: do not infer confidently that every evil is gratuitous, but do not infer confidently that every evil serves a hidden good.

BASIC | 9.6 Theodicy as explanation or moral legitimation**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: [OBJECTION] Theodicy can legitimate the status quo by redescribing oppression as discipline, karma (morally consequential action) or providence.

BASIC 9.7 Does rejecting classical theism dissolve the problem?	
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	Major criticism: The 2024 PYQ is correct that the problem is concept-dependent, but suffering remains philosophically and religiously significant in every framework.
BASIC Session 10 - Comparative Synthesis and Practical Implications	
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	Final verdict: Comparison is strongest when each position is judged through the same axes of ultimate reality, world relation, human relation, causation and religious function.
BASIC 10.1 Multi-axis comparison	
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	High-value transition: Theodicies should be compared through the divine attribute revised, the evil explained, the residual case and the moral cost of the explanation.
BASIC 10.2 Objection-response decision tree	
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	Major criticism: Identify whether the examiner asks contradiction, probability, responsibility, conceptual dependence or religious function.
BASIC 10.3 Practical religious implications	
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	High-value transition: The practical test of a religious response is whether it deepens truthfulness, compassion and responsibility rather than silencing lament.
ADVANCED STAGE	
ADVANCED Advanced-dossier reconciliation — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]	
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	High-value transition: The section dossier marks skeptical theism and horrendous evils as promoted to core because the owner source now teaches CORNEA, representativeness, balancing-off versus defeat, and goodness-to-persons.
ADVANCED Advanced Seminar Modules - From Competent to Examiner-Grade	
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	High-value transition: The logical problem is a question about whether the relevant propositions can be true.

ADVANCED | Modal logic without notation overload**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: The logical problem is a question about whether the relevant propositions can be true.

ADVANCED | The moral premises behind the logical problem**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Major criticism: The logical problem is best understood as a stress-test of perfect goodness under the.

ADVANCED | Freedom: value, range and responsibility**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: Free-will approaches require more than the assertion that freedom is valuable.

ADVANCED | Natural evil: autonomy of creation and excess**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Recommended opening definition: A stable natural order is not merely a stage for morality; it is the condition of embodied.

ADVANCED | Evolutionary evil and deep time**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Recommended opening definition: Deep time is a fairness test for every theodicy.

ADVANCED | Rowe, Draper and cumulative evidence**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: The evidential case is strongest when cumulative rather than dependent on one dramatic.

ADVANCED | Skeptical theism: three boundaries**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Recommended opening definition: Skeptical theism is defensible only when bounded epistemically, morally and religiously.

ADVANCED | Soul-making under the proportionality test**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: Soul-making succeeds for obstacles proportionate to agency and fails when it treats all.

ADVANCED | Augustine after evolutionary criticism**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Major criticism: Corruption remains dependent on an underlying good: disease is malfunction of living.

ADVANCED | Process theology compared with voluntary self-limitation**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Major criticism: Process thought gives the most systematic non-classical response to natural evil, but.

ADVANCED | Karma: desert, causation and social ethics**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Recommended opening definition: A strict desert reading says present suffering is proportionate consequence of prior.

ADVANCED | Advaita and the reality-status objection**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Major criticism: Advaita (non-dual school) changes the problem by distinguishing empirical experience from ultimate.

ADVANCED | Buddhist and Samkhya diagnoses compared**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: This is a reframing, not a victory by default.

ADVANCED | Protest, lament and moral knowledge**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: Protest is philosophically important because it treats the negative moral appearance of.

ADVANCED | Pastoral reason and philosophical restraint**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: The order appropriate to an examination answer is not always the order appropriate at a.

ADVANCED | Full comparative audit grid**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: No theory dominates every axis. The examiner rewards explicit trade-offs: what class of.

ADVANCED | Essay laboratory - Is evil evidence against God or against a concept of God?**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Recommended opening definition: God is finite, processual, impersonal or not a creator, the inference changes.

ADVANCED | Essay laboratory - Could God create virtue without suffering?**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: Some virtue logically requires vulnerability, but it does not follow that the actual.

ADVANCED | Essay laboratory - Is divine permission equivalent to causation?**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: The 2022 PYQ is best answered through layered rather than exclusive responsibility:..

ADVANCED | Essay laboratory - Can eschatology repair theodicy?**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: Eschatology can prevent a life from being finally defeated by evil, but future bliss is.

ADVANCED | Essay laboratory - Does prayer intensify the problem?**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Major criticism: Petitionary prayer can intensify evil's evidential problem because traditions portray God.

ADVANCED | Essay laboratory - The relation between evil and divine hiddenness**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Recommended opening definition: Do not turn this section into a full hiddenness essay or assert that hiddenness is.

ADVANCED | Essay laboratory - Can theism learn from non-theistic traditions?**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Recommended opening definition: The most fruitful comparison is functional and critical: creator-theism supplies a.

ADVANCED | Essay laboratory - Final position options**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Final verdict: The most defensible synthetic judgement is that strict logical incompatibility is not.

REGISTER STAGE**REGISTER | Final Consolidated Register Notes - Problem of Evil****ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Major criticism: Augustine: being is good; evil is privation; defective will; fall/punishment.

REGISTER | A. Argument forms at a glance**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Core argument: Logical: omni-power + perfect goodness + evil + unrestricted bridge premises -> inconsistency.

REGISTER | B. Distinctions that earn marks**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: Separate logical from evidential evil, defence from theodicy, explanation from justification and causal responsibility from moral permission.

REGISTER | C. Western response bank**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Major reply: Plantinga: logical defence; significant freedom; possible transworld depravity.

REGISTER | D. Indian comparison bank**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: Nyaya (school of logic and realism): theistic karmic administration; still faces painful-mechanism question.

REGISTER | E. Hard-case checklist**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: Horrendous evils that destroy agency.

REGISTER | F. Seven PYQ routes**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: 2019: sacred/profane boundary plus evil as soteriological predicament; profane is not evil.

REGISTER | G. 10/15/20-mark answer spines**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

High-value transition: For 10-, 15- and 20-mark answers, expand the same spine—definition, reconstruction, objection-reply and verdict—in proportion to the marks and directive.

REGISTER | H. Final judgement ladder**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE —
WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM**

Final verdict: Best: The problem is concept-dependent yet irreducibly evidential and moral; no response is adequate unless it states its burden, treats animals and horrors seriously, avoids victim blame, and strengthens compassionate action.

REGISTER

Final source-complete rapid recall: distinctions, traps, routes and verdicts.

REGISTER NODE 1 | Final Consolidated Register Notes - Problem of Evil

Register route marker retained.



REGISTER NODE 2 | A. Argument forms at a glance

- Logical: omni-power + perfect goodness + evil + unrestricted bridge premises -> inconsistency.
- Plantinga reply: significant freedom and feasible-world limits make compatibility possible.
- Evidential: apparently gratuitous suffering probably exists -> perfect theism probably false.
- Rowe pressure: fawn; no visible greater good or prevented worse evil.
- Skeptical-theist reply: limited access weakens noseeum inference; bound it to avoid moral skepticism.
- Existential: asks how trust and meaning survive.
- Anti-theodicy: asks whether comprehensive justification wrongs victims.



REGISTER NODE 3 | B. Distinctions that earn marks — continued 1/2

- | Do not collapse | Precise distinction |
- | --- | --- |
- | Defence / theodicy | Possible compatibility / actual-probable divine reason |
- | Explanation / justification | Cause or mechanism / moral permissibility |
- | Compatibility / probability | No contradiction / evidential expectation |
- | Moral / natural / metaphysical evil | Wrong agency / non-voluntary harm / finitude |
- | Suffering / wrongdoing | Experienced harm / culpable action |
- | Compensation / defeat | Later good / evil integrated within sufferer's good |



REGISTER NODE 4 | B. Distinctions that earn marks — continued 2/2

| Privation / illusion | Dependent lack / unreality |

| Humility / paralysis | Limited knowledge / refusal of moral action |



REGISTER NODE 5 | C. Western response bank — continued 1/2

- Augustine: being is good; evil is privation; defective will; fall/punishment.

Strong on anti-dualism, weak on evolutionary and innocent suffering.

- Plantinga: logical defence; significant freedom; possible transworld depravity.

Strong on moral compatibility, weak as total explanation.

- Hick: image-to-likeness development; epistemic distance; stable risky world; eschatological completion.

Strong on growth, weak on horrors and animals.

- Leibniz: best compossible totality.

Strong on systemic trade-offs, weak on victim-centered justification.



REGISTER NODE 6 | C. Western response bank — continued 2/2

- Law order: regularity enables knowledge and agency.

Necessary-condition insight, not proof of every excess.

- Process: distributed power, initial aim, persuasive God, consequent reception.

Innocence and solidarity bought by revised sovereignty.

- Skeptical theism: epistemic undercutting; use modestly.

- Adams: horrendous evil, goodness-to-persons, defeat rather than balancing-off.

- Protest: Job, Ivan, Camus and post-Holocaust caution expose moral limits of explanation.



REGISTER NODE 7 | D. Indian comparison bank

- Nyaya (school of logic and realism): theistic karmic administration; still faces painful-mechanism question.
- Mimamsa (inquiry into Vedic duty): non-creator karmic efficacy through action and apurva (unseen potency generated by ritual duty).
- Advaita (non-dual school): avidya (ignorance of reality), karma (morally consequential action) and empirical suffering under ultimate non-duality; never call empirical pain simply unreal.
- Visistadvaita (qualified non-dualism)/Dvaita: real world, personal God, agency, karma and grace; do not merge with Advaita.
- Samkhya (dualist school based on enumerated principles): creatorless bondage through purusha (pure conscious self)-prakrti (primordial material nature) misidentification; liberation by discrimination.
- Buddhism: dukkha (suffering or unsatisfactoriness), dependent origination, cessation and path; reframes rather than theodicies.
- Jainism: karmic matter, jiva (individual living self), influx/bondage/stoppage/shedding, ahimsa (non-violence) and self-effort.
- Karma critique: victim blame, regress, identity, memory, proportionality and social legitimization.



REGISTER NODE 8 | E. Hard-case checklist

- Pre-human and animal suffering.
- Horrendous evils that destroy agency.
- Unequal distribution and epistemic opportunity.
- Free will in heaven.
- Selective intervention within stable laws.
- Hiddenness to sincere sufferers.
- Compensation versus justification.
- Whether revision leaves a worship-worthy God.



REGISTER NODE 9 | F. Seven PYQ routes

- 2019: sacred/profane boundary plus evil as soteriological predicament; profane is not evil.
- 2020: triad, bridges, Plantinga, logical/evidential distinction.
- 2021: logically possible power, freedom, natural-evil residue.
- 2022: layered responsibility: creator, permission and derivative agency.
- 2023: privation + free will + punishment; evolutionary and innocent-suffering critique.
- 2024: organize by God-concept; preserve versus revise versus remove creator.
- 2025: process metaphysics, initial aim, persuasive necessity, solidarity and sovereignty cost.



REGISTER NODE 10 | G. 10/15/20-mark answer spines — continued 1/2

10 marks:

Define exact problem -> reconstruct 3-4 premises -> one objection/reply -> verdict.

15 marks:

Direct thesis -> distinctions -> named argument -> strongest objection ->

strongest reply -> one comparison -> residual cost -> verdict.

20 marks:

Conceptual map -> formal/causal reconstruction -> two levels of criticism ->

reply and counter-reply -> Indian/Western comparison ->



REGISTER NODE 11 | G. 10/15/20-mark answer spines — continued 2/2

victim-centered ethical test -> graded judgement.



REGISTER NODE 12 | H. Final judgement ladder

- Too strong: "Evil disproves every God and every religion."
- Too weak: "Free will completely solves evil."
- Better: Plantinga defeats a simple contradiction but not evidential or existential evil.
- Strong: Different theodicies explain different classes of evil while carrying distinct costs.
- Best: The problem is concept-dependent yet irreducibly evidential and moral; no response is adequate unless it states its burden, treats animals and horrors seriously, avoids victim blame, and strengthens compassionate action.

[MEMORY] D-R-O-R-V - Define, Reconstruct, Objection, Reply, Verdict.

End state: The candidate should be able to formalize the logical and evidential arguments, compare preservation and revision strategies, distinguish Indian schools, answer all seven verified PYQs and refuse both facile optimism and facile dismissal.